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TUESDAY, 25 AUGUST 2026

At least a dozen celebrities and influencers, including a top Bollywood actor, have halted new endorsements for many F&B brands amid regulatory crackdown ▶ P 1

▶ Singtel Joins Queue to India's Satcom Space ▶ India Inc Steps Up Equity Fundraising amid Strong Inflows ▶ TCS Inks \$1.45b Deal with Porsche: P 1



The Symphony of Us

*One Artist. One Institution.
One New India.*

An artist, whose music
the world already knows.

An institution, that has stood
with this nation for a century.

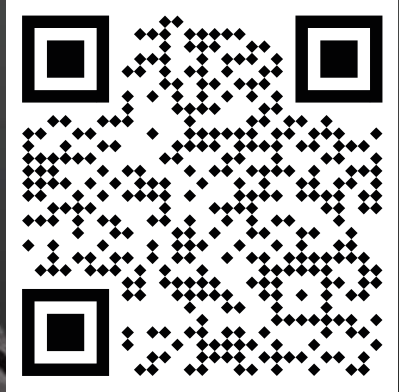
A nation, that is writing
its new story.

A song, that is the voice of
this new India.

NOW STREAMING ON



WATCH THE VIDEO



Ricky Kej
Three-time Grammy Award winner



Twists & Turns of AI Tech Race

Ahead of the upcoming IPO of Anthropic, leaked reports suggest that the firm is seeking a valuation of \$2 trillion, potentially making it the biggest listing ever. The company's revenue is almost double that of OpenAI, and it has also reportedly turned profitable. Let's see how the big AI labs are faring.



Anthropic Claude 11.6B

OpenAI GPT 6.7B

xAI Grok ~500M

Deepseek Deepseek ~500M

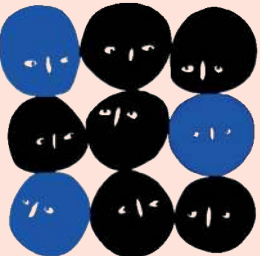
Mistral ~400M

We can see a trillion dollars of AI infrastructure revenue over the next three years
Jensen Huang

Probably our AI revenue will exceed all other SpaceX revenue in September
Elon Musk

Source: Investor reports, Company disclosure and media reports

AI LAYOFF TRACKER



Apple	200
Motive	251
Rapid7	313
Salesforce	133
TikTok	250
Zillow	500
Chime	150
Visa	2,600
Amazon	1,100
Monday.com	630

(Since Jan 2026, in chronological order)

THE GOOD

AI-based Screening Can Spot Eye Diseases Faster

A study in the European Journal of Ophthalmology found that a smartphone-based offline AI system can detect diabetic retinopathy, glaucoma and age-related macular degeneration. The study highlights potential of AI-powered retinal screening to expand access to diagnostics.

THE BAD



MIT's New Study Finds AI 'Attribution Decay'

New work from a team of researchers at MIT has identified a phenomenon they call "attribution decay", where the more data a generative model is trained on, the less any individual training example matters to a particular output.

THE UGLY

A Third of New Web Pages Are Now Written by AI

More than a third of web pages published after the release of ChatGPT show signs of being written by AI, according to a Pew Research study. The study also found that much of the browsing being done was by bots reading web pages written by other bots.

Vibe-coding Apps Gun for Indian Geek Love

On a sunny August afternoon, a couple of hundred developers, from fresh graduates to seasoned software builders, gathered at Cafe Cursor, a community event organised by Cursor in Bengaluru. Over steaming cups of cappuccino, with headphones on, some developers typed or talked their way through prompts at beige tables at Araku, the cafe where the event was held during the weeklong tech event Basecamp, organised by Elevation Capital.

Some came for curiosity and coffee; others to build, explore and meet fellow AI enthusiasts. Conversations ranged from agents and GrokBot to an obsession with AI tools.

The event is part of Cursor's effort to engage with India's developer community, where its user base has tripled in the past year to three million developers, the company said in a blog post. Armed with fresh capital following Elon Musk's acquisition, the company is preparing to open an office and expand its team in India as it steps up efforts to capture the country's developer base.

Cursor is not alone in wooing Indian builders. A new kind of war is brewing for the mindscape of Indian developers, who form one of the largest and fastest-growing developer populations in the world. Over the past few months, AI giants OpenAI and Anthropic have doubled down on the India market and significantly expanded their teams. The push comes amid rapid adoption of AI by Indian enterprises and startups. As companies look to improve productivity, the use of AI tools has risen over the past two years. As the capabilities of these tools improve, the share of code written by AI has crossed more than half at some companies, while AI-native startups are building extensively on these coding tools. With the tools seeing significant adoption, AI coding platforms are looking to tap into this fast-growing market, with no clear winner yet.

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CLAMOURING FOR ATTENTION

According to data from media sources, Claude Code, Cursor and Codex are among the fastest-growing platforms. Data from software development firm JetBrains shows Claude Code with a 39% market share, followed by Codex at 16% and Cursor at 12%. While Claude Code and Codex are going head-to-head, Cursor users say the coding platform occupies a different position.

"You can use the same models you are using on Claude or Codex, without locking in the model. Cursor has built a better coding harness, which knows your codebases better and with Cursor agents, the entire process from coding to review is now seamless," one of them said.

Multiple developers ET spoke to said Claude Code remained a dominant player, but as OpenAI's underlying AI models improve, Codex is seeing significant adoption, along with Chinese AI models.

This marks a shift from how developers were using the platforms six months ago. A JetBrains report shows Codex usage jumping from 3% in January to 16% in July 2026.

Soumyo Sinha, cofounder, SentLogix Labs, an AI startup focused on media and content, said Claude Code was a dominant platform, but about 40% of his work now happens on Codex, 30% on Claude Code and the rest on Chinese open-source models such as Kimi and GLM. "I am spending \$100

Cursor, OpenAI and Anthropic are turning up the heat in the race to win India's fast-growing tribe of AI builders, writes Swathi Moorthy



BULLSEYE!

A SNAPSHOT OF ACTIVE USERS

AI Model	Company	Active users Metric/Period
Codex	OpenAI	20m (weekly) August 21, 2026
Claude	Anthropic	245m (monthly) May 2026
ChatGPT	OpenAI	1.1b (monthly) June 2026
Gemini	Google	1b (monthly) August 2026
Grok	xAI	64m (monthly) August 2026
DeepSeek	DeepSeek	97m (monthly) July 2026

60% Of all new code written will be AI generated by the end of 2026, projects Gartner

45% Of developers find debugging AI-generated code more time-consuming

Source: Media reports & ET Research

each for Codex, Claude Code and Chinese models, which are good and cheap," he said.

In a report released in June, India was identified as one of the fastest-growing markets for Codex, with the platform seeing fourfold growth in February. Codex has five million weekly active users as of June 2026. Claude has anywhere between 20 to 30 million monthly active users on its consumer tier, which comprises paying customers, according to industry estimates. Claude Code is part of the paid tiers.

CLAUDE CODE VS CODEX: WHAT CHANGED

Pratyush Choudhury, cofounder and managing partner of AI-focused early-stage fund Activate, said Claude Code was clearly ahead earlier this year. But as workflows became more intensive, practical constraints around latency, availability and rate limits began to matter.

Meanwhile, OpenAI has closed much of the capability gap with Codex, stronger model releases such as GPT-5.5 and GPT-5.6, and high-quality computer-use capabilities. Computer use is a Codex feature that allows AI to click, type and move the mouse, going beyond writing code.

"For knowledge-work automation and operator-style AI workflows, Codex has become the more practical default for me," he said.

Choudhury also pointed to compute constraints, saying Anthropic had reduced rate limits and Codex offered an alternative for many users. A founder of a cybersecurity startup said that, while Claude Mythos and Fable are celebrated for their cybersecurity models, GPT 5.6 Sol is equally good at security capabilities.

Sidu Ponnappa, cofounder, Realfast.ai, said he had used Claude Code for coding and Codex for review, but this was flipping as Codex's coding performance improved. While Codex is closing the performance gap for now, founders flag that this might not last. Emails sent to Anthropic did not elicit any response till the time of publishing.

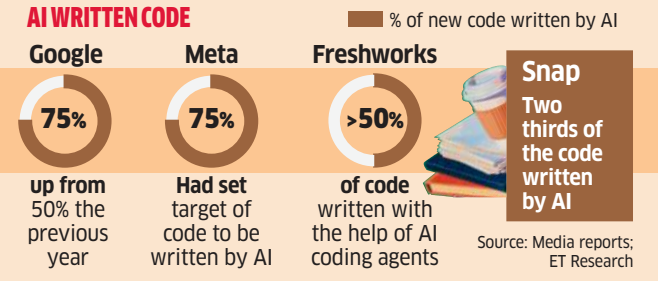
OpenAI's Vaibhav Srivastav, Codex developer experience engineer, said in a media interaction in April that the company was pushing out features to achieve better developer-market fit in India. The firm is also doubling down on partnerships as it builds better models and services for people interacting with Codex, Srivastav added.

CHALLENGES

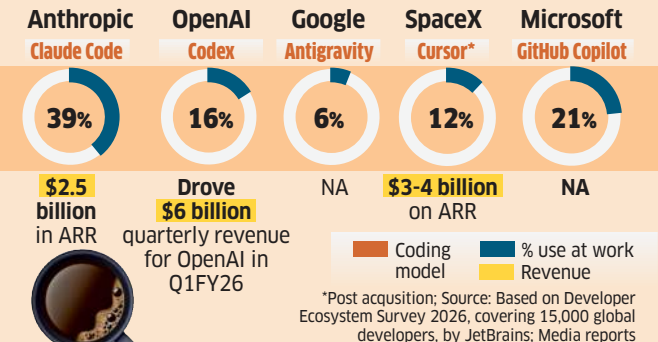
The market is now saturated with AI coding models, and the battle is increasingly about gaining market share, explaining the growing focus on India. What it boils down to is how quickly companies can capture the market and how expensive it is for users to switch. That helps explain the intense community engagement efforts by all these companies.

Shashank Agarwal, cofounder, Noveum.ai, said Cursor would need to improve its models to compete head-on with Claude Code and Codex. While it has its own model, Composer, he said that unless Cursor owns the model game, it could lose its competitive edge.

There is no winner, at least not yet. As Realfast.ai's Ponnappa pointed out, frontier labs are releasing new capabilities every quarter, and the winner can change every three months. Even pricing structures and competitive moats continue to evolve. In the meantime, companies are racing to tap into the market and lock in founders early.



AI MODEL PLAY & MARKET SHARE



VIBE ON TARGET

Unlike Claude Code or Codex, these platforms—barring OpenCode—handle the entire coding process, from building to deploying applications. Many also offer an agentic layer as competition in the space intensifies

Platform	Funding	Revenue
OpenCode	NA	\$40 million
Lovable	\$1 billion at \$6.6 billion valuation	\$500 million ARR as of June 2026
Emergent	\$230 million at \$1.5 billion valuation	\$100 million early 2026
Replit	\$922 million at \$9 billion valuation	\$525 million ARR by April 2026, with the target to reach \$1 billion by end of the year
Vercel	\$863 million at \$9.3 billion population	\$340 million ARR as of Feb 2026

Source: Tracxn; media reports

CHALLENGES

The market is saturated, and the focus is now on who can capture market share the fastest. AI-generated code also presents security risks. According to an IBM report released in June 2026, "while AI-assisted coding is shipping code four times faster, they were shipping 10 times as many security flaws".



Winning with AI

By Parminder Singh

USING AI WITHOUT GIVING AWAY FARM

Recently, Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella said that we pay for AI twice: once when we pay for the tokens and again through the proprietary intelligence we share. Most enterprise AI products say they do not directly use your data to train their models. But the bigger issue is the context and intelligence you end up sharing. Consider an experienced credit officer reviewing a loan proposal. The AI recommends approval. She rejects it.

Why? Perhaps she has learnt from 20 years of bad loans that one apparently innocuous signal deserves closer examination. Do this thousands of times, and you have something more interesting than a database. That is competitive intelligence. Here's a guide to protecting your competitive intelligence.

1. Separate Consumer AI from Enterprise AI

Employees are already using AI. If official tools are cumbersome, they will use whatever is easiest. That's 'shadow AI'. You cannot solve this merely by issuing a circular. Give employees approved enterprise AI tools. Good governance should remove friction, not create it.

2. Classify Knowledge, Not Just Data

Most firms classify data as public, internal, confidential or restricted. Extend the same thinking to AI. Ask: What information would hurt us if a competitor knew it? Before connecting a new data source to AI, understand what that connection exposes.

3. Model Contract Matters More Than Benchmark

CEOs often ask which model performs best. GPT? Claude? Gemini? Before that, ask: What happens to our information? Is it retained or used for training? Who can access it? Can it be deleted? The answers vary by product, configuration and contract. "We use enterprise AI" is not an adequate answer.

5. Own Learning Loop

This may be the most important rule. When an employee corrects an AI agent, where does that knowledge go? When the system learns which approach works better, who captures that learning? That intelligence should remain with your organisation, independent of the model underneath.

4. AI Trust Perimeter

The goal is not to stop AI from accessing enterprise knowledge. That defeats the purpose. The goal is to control how it accesses that knowledge. Documents, databases, permissions, memory, evaluations and feedback should sit inside a clearly defined trust perimeter. Give AI the minimum info required for the task.



American Gothic, 1930 by Grant Wood

Parminder Singh is the CEO of Reliance Enterprise Intelligence (REIL) and cofounder of two AI ventures—ClayboxAI and WeKamp. For feedback, please email to eteyenai@timesofindia.com

WHO LET THE BOTS OUT?

Unchecked AI agents & runaway code sprawl are quietly driving a 2,500% explosion in software defects, along with security and governance risks, writes Himanshi Lohchab

WHO LET THE BOTS OUT?

The software bug should have taken minutes to fix. Instead, it took two days. The engineer debugging the failure had never seen the logic before. It had been generated by one AI model, modified by another and deployed automatically by an AI agent.

As more companies rely on AI to write software, developers are increasingly finding themselves maintaining code that no human fully understands. The result is a new enterprise problem that technology leaders are calling "code sprawl".

Tools such as GitHub Copilot, Anthropic's Claude Code, Cursor and OpenAI's Codex have significantly reduced development timelines, but their ungoverned use is creating new layers of technical debt. Code sprawl occurs when developers use multiple AI coding assistants and autonomous agents to generate vast amounts of code without central oversight or governance.

According to an Hfs Research survey of 123 large enterprises, 43% already report AI creating new technical debt. Gartner projects software defects could rise by 2,500% by 2028 as rapid "prompt-to-app" development scales without proper architectural governance. Meanwhile, IDC estimates organisations that fail to tackle technical debt will face 50% higher failure rates and rising costs for AI initiatives by 2027.

"This has become a boardroom issue, not just an engineering one," said Nick Eayrs, vice-president, field engineering, Asia Pacific and Japan, at Databricks. "Code and agent sprawl happens when AI coding tools and the agents they spin up multiply faster than an organisation can keep



track of. It usually starts innocently, one team adopts an AI coding assistant, another builds an agent for a specific workflow, and within months, an enterprise has hundreds of agents in production with no view of what exists or what data it

can touch." Gartner estimates that the average Fortune 500 enterprise may be running well over 100,000 AI agents within the next few years, while fewer than one in six organisations say they have adequate governance in place.

"This is causing a rise in 'shadow AI', similar to how 'shadow IT' emerged in the early 2000s

during the cloud computing boom. As SaaS platforms such as Dropbox, Google Drive, Slack, Trello and Zoom became available, employees could sign up with nothing more than a credit card or corporate email. Business units began adopting their own tools without involving IT, giving rise to 'shadow IT'.

The irony is that AI-generated code often looks good when reviewed. According to New Relic's 2026 State of AI Coding Report, 94% of engineering leaders rated AI-generated code as higher quality than human-written code. Yet once that code reaches production, 78% reported an increase in production incidents. "Engineering teams are shipping code at record speeds, but when an outage occurs, Mean Time to Resolution increases because developers are debugging dense logic they did not write line-by-line," said Ganesh Narasimhadevara, director, solutions consulting, New Relic India.

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THE ECONOMIC TIMES
STARTUP AWARDS 2026

ETSA Jury Picks the Winners Today



Today, an elite panel, led by Wipro's **Rishad Premji**, enters the jury room to pick the winners of the 12th edition of **The Economic Times Startup Awards**, the country's most treasured recognition for entrepreneurial excellence. The jury comprises Paytm founder and CEO Vijay Shekhar Sharma, Myntra and Curefit cofounder Mukesh Bansal, Flipkart and Navi cofounder Sachin Bansal, CaratLane cofounder Mithun Sacheti, Swiggy Instamart CEO Nandita Sinha, Snap CBO Ajit Mohan, Anthropic India MD Irina Ghose, Wingify and Lossfunk founder Paras Chopra, Urban Company cofounder and CEO Abhiraj Singh Bhal and Aditya Birla Group director Aryaman Vikram Birla.

Watch out for ET's full coverage.

REACHING FOR THE STARS

Singtel Joins Queue to India's Satcom Space

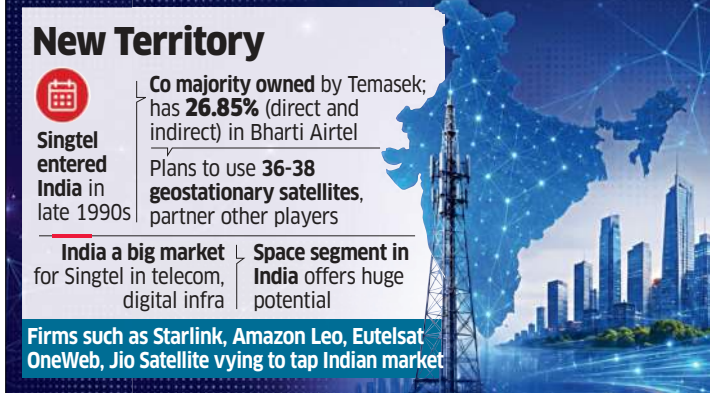
Plans to offer satellite comm-related services; seeks FDI nod for arm to expand offerings

Kiran Rathee

New Delhi: Singapore Telecommunications (Singtel) is looking to start satellite communication-related services in India, becoming the latest global aspirant in the country's nascent but high-potential satcom market.

Singtel plans to target both public and private enterprises with its satcom offerings through its wholly owned unit, Singapore Telecom India (STIPL), people familiar with the matter told ET.

The company has sought foreign direct investment (FDI) approval from the Centre for its plan, the people said. "While STIPL has been operational in India for more than two decades, a fresh FDI nod is needed as the company is expanding its scope to include satellite communication-related services," said one of the



RCom, Lenders Get Relief in Bank Guarantee Encashment Case >> 5

Delhi HC Directs Income Tax Dept to Refund ₹53cr to Voda Idea >> 5

persons cited, requesting anonymity as the details are not public.

Singtel didn't respond to an email query. The company, majority owned by Singapore's state investment firm Temasek Holdings, is a significant stakeholder in Bharti Airtel, India's second largest telecom operator, with 26.85% direct and indi-

rect stake.

A government official confirmed Singtel's application is being considered but declined to elaborate.

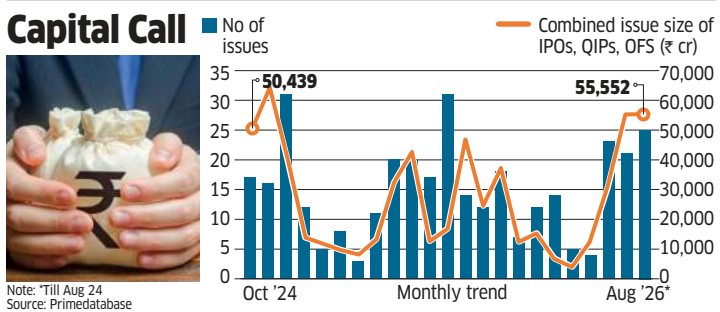
"The company plans to offer satcom services by utilising a global network of around 36-38 geostationary (GEO) satellites as well as through partnerships with players like Elon Musk-owned Starlink," a second person said. Singtel also has a platform that allows integration of multiple orbit satellites.

No Launches Yet >> 8

MOOD UPBEAT DESPITE RANGE-BOUND MOVEMENT IN KEY INDICES

India Inc's Equity Fundraising in Top Gear on Strong Inflows

₹1.1Lcr mobilised through July-Aug via IPOs, QIPs & OFS nearly a 2-yr high



Note: Till Aug 24
Source: Primedatabase

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: Corporate India raised more than ₹1.11 lakh crore through mainboard initial public offerings (IPOs), qualified institutional placements and offers for sale through July and August, as domestic liquidity and improving investor sentiment kept the capital markets active despite range-bound movements in key equity gauges.

The two-month fundraising tally is the highest since October-November

2024, when more than ₹1.14 lakh crore was raised through these routes.

IPO activity remained particularly strong, garnering more than 40% of the funds raised. So far this month, 20 companies have collected more than ₹20,850 crore, adding on to the ₹28,650 crore raised by 12 companies in July. Listed companies have also stepped up qualified institutional placements (QIP), with four companies raising ₹3,250 cro-

re so far in August, against ₹25,114 crore by eight companies in July.

In the offer for sale (OFS) segment, where existing investors cash out in part, Life Insurance Corp of India raised nearly ₹31,447 crore in August to boost public float in the country's biggest institutional investor.

Volatility Hit Transactions >> 8

Investors' Equity Rush Helps SIP Assets Triple in 5 Yrs >> 7

ALL-CASH TRANSACTION

TCS Signs \$1.4b 5-Year Deal with Porsche AG

Also buys German auto co's IT arm for \$373m

Our Bureau

Bengaluru | New Delhi: India's largest IT services provider, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), signed a five-year deal with Porsche AG valued at €1.25 billion (\$1.45 billion) and acquired the German automaker's IT arm, MHP, for €320 million (\$373.4 million) in an all-cash transaction. The two deals are independent of each other.

The scale of opportunity is the primary motivation, TCS chief executive K Krithivasan told ET.

"Currently, MHP operates only in Europe, and now we are able to operate at a global scale with this combined entity," he said. "Porsche will be our customer zero, but our centre will bring solutions to all other automobile customers, expanding the scale and scope of what we can do together."

Michael Leiters, chief executive officer of the Volkswagen Group-owned sports and luxury car manufacturer, said in the joint ET interview that although MHP is a key subsidiary and IT solutions are critical, Porsche wants to focus on its core business. "We think that MHP is in much better hands in TCS because they have the breadth to extend business opportunities for MHP," he said.

Centre of Excellence to be Set Up >> 8

REGULATORY HEAT ON F&B SECTOR

Stars Won't Burn Fingers on Food Inc's Hot Potato

Many pause, refuse or even abandon endorsements to steer clear of flak

Ratna Bhushan

New Delhi: At least a dozen celebrities and influencers, including a leading Bollywood actor, have halted new endorsements for several food and beverage brands, amid regulatory crackdown on the sector, people aware of the decisions told ET. The screen star has said no to a global chocolate brand, while another celebrity has walked out of a deal with one of India's largest snacks firms ahead of the upcoming high-sales season, they said.

"This comes ahead of peak festive season when, typically, a lot of indulgence gifting categories, such as chocolates and gourmet snacks, sign big-ticket endorsement deals," said the chief of a leading Mumbai-based talent management firm. "This is the first time we are seeing such pushback from celebrities and influencers. We have cancelled two such deals for which we had been in talks since April."

This celebrity rethink comes as the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) faces unprecedented judicial heat on mandatory labelling of packaged foods that are high in salt, sugar or fat content.

Image Matters More >> 8

CONSUMER COS' FOREX EARNINGS SHINE >> 9

Look Before Leap

FSSAI to Celebs

Before endorsing a food product, ensure claims are truthful

Promoting misleading/unverified claims can have legal consequences

FSSAI 150+ notices to packaged F&B cos over alleged misleading

These include Nestle, Mondelez, Danone, Ferrero and Coca-Cola

Maharashtra FDA Showcase notices to Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn, Tiger Shroff for endorsing Vimal Elaichi

Image of three people holding up products

PURE POLITICS

3 Fugitive Gangsters Deported from Malaysia

Indian agencies got three gangsters apprehended in Malaysia, deported and sent to police custody, home minister Amit Shah said on X. The fugitives – Jaspreet Singh, Ajay Singh and Pawandeep Singh – are linked to the Bamba gang and allegedly also to terror operations. **Rahul Tripathi** reports. >> 2

Panel told to Prioritise Assault Cases of Women Protesters: CJI >> 2

India Reaches Out to Russia with PM Modi's Letter to Putin >> 3

ANOTHER 1,325 MW OF GREEN ENERGY

Suzlon Plans ₹10,000cr Andhra Wind Projects

Suzlon Group is set to develop 1,325 MW of new wind energy projects in Andhra Pradesh's Rayadurg constituency in Anantapur, at an investment of around ₹10,000 crore, as the firm expands its renewable energy footprint in the state. **Shilpa Ranipeta** reports. >> 8

Goyal Urges Japanese Cos to Deepen Localisation in India >> 4

DRL & Emcure Get Approval to Make Breakthrough HIV Drug >> 5

OUR NCD PUBLIC ISSUE 7 WAS OVERSUBSCRIBED BY 704% WITHIN 3 DAYS

INDEL MONEY



LINKED TO BAMBIHA GANG, ACCUSED OF MULTIPLE CRIMES

Three Fugitive Gangsters Deported from Malaysia

Lawrence Bishnoi gang and Bambiha gang are rivals: NIA

Rahul Tripathi

New Delhi: Indian agencies got three fugitive Indian gangsters apprehended in Malaysia, deported them, and sent them to police custody, Union home minister Amit Shah said in a post on X.

The fugitives — Jaspreet Singh, Ajay Singh and Pawandeep Singh — are linked to Bambiha gang and are accused of multiple crimes, including extortion, cross-border arms and narco-trafficking and a foiled grenade attack in Ludhiana. They allegedly also had links with terror operations and anti-national groups.



Jaspreet had planned a grenade attack in Ludhiana; it was foiled by Punjab Police



Multiple cases filed against these three under UAPA, IPC, BNS and Narcotics Act

Jaspreet Singh, a prime conduit of the Bambiha gang, was continuously in touch with the kingpins of the syndicate: Lucky Patiyal, Mann Ghanshyampuria and Doni Bal, said sources at investigative agencies. Closely linked to criminal entities in Canada, he had planned a grenade attack in October 2025 at a marketplace in Ludhiana, which was foiled by Punjab Police. A case was registered against him at Jodhpur police station in Ludhiana. Multiple criminal cases are registered against these three under sections of Unlawful Activities



Deported Since 2019
274 fugitive criminals from 36 countries, including 26/11 prime accused Tahawwur Rana

AGENCIES' 3-PRONGED STRATEGY
Global outreach, strong coordination and diplomacy

FUGITIVE MANAGEMENT
A standing focus group under multi-agency centre of Intelligence Bureau created in January this year

Shah Lays Stress on Training to Implement PRAHAAR

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Union home minister Amit Shah on Monday laid emphasis on training for implementing MHA's PRAHAAR scheme, expecting trials by bringing back fugitives and using trial-in-absentia provisions, and undertaking a comprehensive and in-

tegrated approach while investigating UAPA cases. Speaking at the 9th two-day National Security Strategies conference here, he directed that an AI-based analysis of information available on MAC platforms should be done to create SOPs to counter security challenges. Shah directed all agencies to take strict measures against infiltration.

(Prevention) Act, Indian Penal Code, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Narcotics Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act in Punjab and Rajasthan. They were deported on August 18 and were handed over to the Punjab Police. As per NIA, the Lawrence Bishnoi gang and Bambiha gang are rivals. Many fugitives changed their identities while residing abroad. However, using advanced tech-

nology and profile mapping, Indian agencies were able to identify and trace them. Technology was also leveraged to expedite extradition and deportation, including the use of videoconferencing for court hearings. Agencies have got 51 hardened criminals deported to India in 2026, as per officials. In the past three years, Red Corner Notices have been issued against 401 fugitives.



SPACE MATTER

Why Strangulate ISRO With Privatisation Push: Congress

'ISRO has done India proud & the PM has basked in the glory of its achievements'

Our Political Bureau

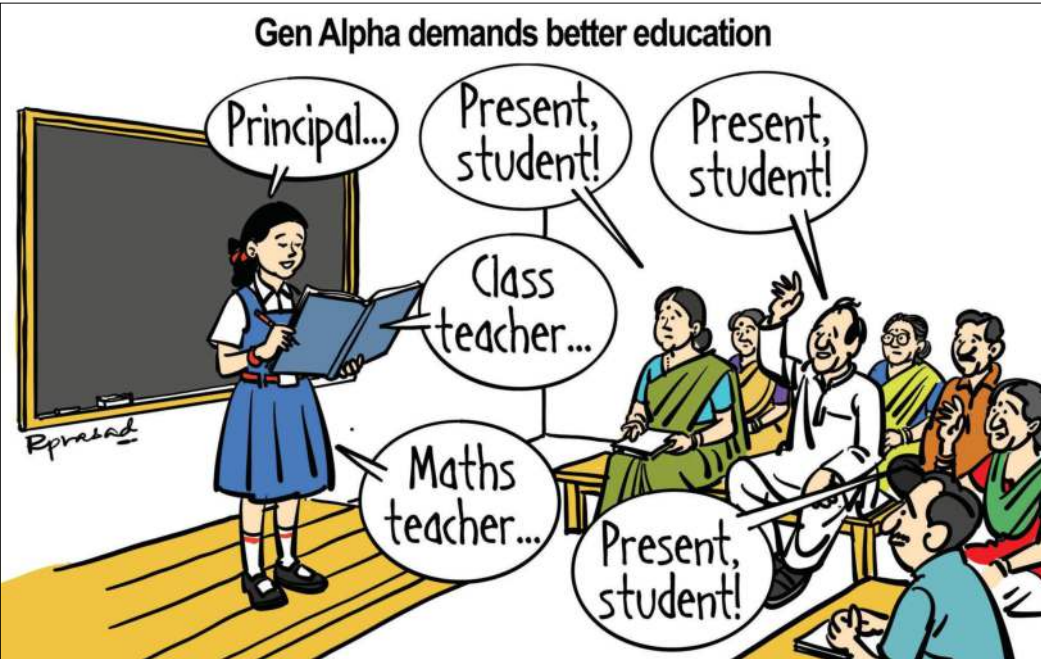
New Delhi: Congress has accused the Narendra Modi government of embarking on an "aggressive privatisation" of India's space programme that will "limit" the Indian Space Research Organisation's presence in rocket development and manufacture, and asked why ISRO be "strangled and emasculated".

Congress spokesman Jairam Ramesh alleged the privatisation agenda would mean transferring much of ISRO's satellite-related assets lock, stock and barrel to private companies. "ISRO has done India enormously proud and the prime minister himself has basked in the glory of its achievements on multiple occasions. Space startups certainly deserve encouragement and support. But why should ISRO, which has for long had productive partnerships with the private sector, now be strangulated and emasculated?" Ramesh said.

He noted that "a distinguished former ISRO chairman, who had joined BJP" (G Madhavan Nair), has also expressed serious doubts on the privatisation drive involving ISRO. "Why don't the five other living eminent chairmen also speak out on this vital issue?" Ramesh added.

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Gen Alpha demands better education

CJP-LED JANTAR MANTAR PROTESTS

Panel Asked to Prioritise Sexual Assault Cases: CJI

'Committee must submit an interim report on complaints at the earliest'

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Monday said the high-powered panel constituted to examine the allegations of police violence during the recent student protests has been urged to take up on priority the complaints of sexual assault faced by women protesters. As per last week's order, the committee must submit an interim report on sexual assault complaints at the earliest.

Justice Kant said after senior advocate Shobha Gupta requested the Supreme Court's suo motu cognizance of the cases of sexual assault during the Jantar Mantar protests led by Cockroach Janta Party on July 20. Last week, the Supreme Court constituted a five-member panel, headed by retired SC judge R Subhash Reddy, to probe accusations of police excesses against protesters. Gupta said there are widely reported complaints of girls facing sexual assault from police personnel.

Justice Joydip Bagchi, a member of the bench headed by the CJI, said an independent writ petition was filed on the same cause, and the high-powered panel has been asked to examine the issue. Gupta, however, requested that sexual assault cases be investigated separately, and a district judge be designated before whom women can submit their complaints directly.

'NO CHILD SHOULD BE FORCED TO STUDY IN SUCH CONDITIONS' Children Being Treated Worse Than Animals: CJP Writes to States, Seeks Data on School Infra



NEW DELHI: Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), which has put the state of government schools at the centre of its ongoing campaign, wrote to all state governments on Monday, seeking data on school infrastructure, teacher vacancies and funding over the last five years. In identical letters addressed to education ministers, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said visuals from government schools circulating on social media showed that many children still lacked basic facilities such as safe drinking water, functional toilets, proper classrooms and even benches. "It has been 80 years since India gained Independence... No child in this country should be forced to study in such conditions. They are being treated worse than animals," Dipke wrote. -PTI

Justice Kant then pointed out that the order dated August 18 has specifically mentioned this issue. "The committee has been requested to examine it on a priority basis, and immediately submit an interim report," he said.

AGITATION ENDS AFTER DISTRICT ADMIN ANNOUNCES A TEAM TO PROBE ALLEGATIONS

Livid Over 'Casteist Remarks' by Teachers, 200 MP Students March 25 km in Protest

BARWANI: Around 200 students marched 25 km on Monday, seeking action against teachers of a government residential school in Madhya Pradesh's Barwani district for allegedly using casteist slurs and behaving indecently with them. The students, whose spontaneous agitation caused traffic jams on a busy national highway, ended their protest only after the district administration announced the formation of a team to investigate their allegations. Eyewitnesses said around 200 students from Eklavya Adarsh Residential School in Jamli, located about 60 km from the district headquarters, began the march to the district magistrate's office. Students also alleged that they were not allowed to meet their family members in the hostel and were treated indecently. -PTI

Poliloquy R PRASAD



Manusmriti? Sorry, I didn't keep my copy.

SC Seeks Kerala Response on Death Row Convict's Transfer Plea

RAPE-MURDER OF A LAW STUDENT Petitioner Ameer-UI-Islam seeking transfer from Viyyur Central Prison in Kerala to a jail in Assam

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Monday sought Kerala government's response on a plea filed by death row convict Muhammed Ameer-UI-Islam, seeking transfer from a Kerala jail to an Assam prison. Ameer-UI-Islam is the sole convict sentenced to death for rape and murder of a Dalit law student in Kerala's Perumbavoor in 2016. A bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu issued notice on his plea, seeking transfer from Viyyur Central Prison in Kerala to a jail in Assam, where his wife and aged parents reside. Ameer-UI-Islam's counsel argued that a prisoner sentenced to death cannot ordinarily be transferred without special permission from the government, except in circumstances where the prisoner's presence is required before a court. The counsel said the proceedings referred to in the provision had already concluded, pointing out that the Kerala High Court had confirmed the death sentence.

plea, seeking transfer from Viyyur Central Prison in Kerala to a jail in Assam, where his wife and aged parents reside. Ameer-UI-Islam's counsel argued that a prisoner sentenced to death cannot ordinarily be transferred without special permission from the government, except in circumstances where the prisoner's presence is required before a court. The counsel said the proceedings referred to in the provision had already concluded, pointing out that the Kerala High Court had confirmed the death sentence.

PETITIONER'S COUNSEL

'Assam yet to consider the issue... It will decide only after Kerala permits the transfer'

SC, however, asked whether Assam has consented to the proposed transfer. The counsel for the convict submitted

SC Restores Before HC Poll Petition of Cong's LS Candidate from Assam

NEW DELHI: SC on Monday restored an election petition filed by Congress candidate Hafiz Rashid Ahmed Choudhury, challenging the election of BJP's Kripanath Mallah, who won the 2024 Lok Sabha poll against him from Karimganj in Assam. A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran allowed Choudhury's plea, saying it finds absolutely no reason to sustain the April 4, 2025, order of the Gauhati High Court dismissing the petition. -PTI

The counsel appearing for Assam also told the bench that the state would consider the request if Kerala allowed the transfer. The apex court subsequently issued notice to the Kerala government asking it to file its response.

PC Dubs One Nation, One Poll 'Monstrous'; Vidhi Centre Flags Constitutional Risks

Jatin Takkar

New Delhi: Former Union minister P Chidambaram on Monday dubbed the proposed 'one nation, one election' (ONOE) plan 'monstrous' and 'unconstitutional' while think tank Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy urged extensive changes to the proposed framework. Rajya Sabha MP and Congress leader Chidambaram was invited by the joint parliamentary committee examining the Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, 2024, and other enabling bills for ONOE. Swapnil Tripathi from Vidhi Centre also briefed the panel. Chidambaram argued curtailing the tenure of elected legislatures would violate the Constitution's basic structure as legislatures are elected for a five-year term, sources aware of the deliberations said. He asserted that the government did not have the two-thirds majority required to pass the Constitution amendment, the sources added. According to the presentation by Vidhi

JOINT PARLIAMENTARY COMMITTEE ON SIMULTANEOUS POLL

hi Centre, which has worked with the Centre on about 50 projects including Jan Vishwas and Aadhaar Act, the proposed ONOE framework needs significant safeguards and redrafting to withstand constitutional scrutiny. The proposed Article 82A(3), which empowers Election Commission of India to modify constitutional provisions to implement ONOE, 'could violate the basic structure of Constitution by effectively delegating the amending powers of Parliament'. It also flagged conflict of interest by allowing ECI to modify provisions governing elections.

Vidhi further proposed clearly defining the grounds on which state elections may be deferred, restricting the scope of President's Rule by requiring polls to be held within six months. ISSUES RAISED BEFORE PARLIAMENTARY PANEL Cong leader Chidambaram says proposal violates Constitution's basic structure; Vidhi Centre seeks major rewrite, highlights excessive powers to Election Commission

posed Article 82A(3), which empowers Election Commission of India to modify constitutional provisions to implement ONOE, 'could violate the basic structure of Constitution by effectively delegating the amending powers of Parliament'. It also flagged conflict of interest by allowing ECI to modify provisions governing elections.

JPC chairman and BJP MP PP Chaudhary said Chidambaram offered "good inputs", but represented a particular political viewpoint. He said ONOE doesn't violate the Constitution's basic structure and said the committee would examine all submissions before making its recommendations.



If states decide in favour of 'one nation, one election', that state elections be held along with Lok Sabha polls, then it is possible. It is up to them what they decide. The Constitution allows that; it is permissible. Under the Constitution, states are empowered to hold simultaneous poll

PP CHAUDHARY JPC CHAIRMAN

HOUSES BURNT, DAMAGED IN SENAPATI AND ADJOINING AREAS OF KANGPOKPI

CRPF Constable Injured in Fresh Manipur Firing

Firing took place from multiple sides: Police

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: A CRPF constable sustained injury in fresh firing in Senapati and adjoining areas of Kangpokpi district when media persons tried to record footage of houses which were burnt and damaged early Monday morning. A police official said the first incident of houses being burnt was reported at 2.40 am at Taphou Kuki. Other incidents were reported after 4 am around Mareimei, where houses belonging to Naga residents were burnt down. The house belonging to a resident of Lai village and another one belonging to a resident



Violence in Senapati

of Phuba village were also burnt. "The constable is undergoing treatment at the district hospital, Senapati. The firing took place from multiple sides," the official said. Protestors blocked NH-2, the Imphal-Dimapur highway. The Taphou Kuki Village Authority, in a statement on Monday, condemned the burning and destruction of a residential house belonging to a Taphou Kuki villager, describing the incident as "deplorable, inhuman and unacceptable".

Fresh 'Threat' to KP Govt Staff in Valley Prompts Calls for Extra Security, Probe

JAMMU: Kashmiri Pandit government employees working in the Valley have expressed concern over fresh terror threats after posters allegedly containing names and personal details of some of them were circulated on social media, calling for enhanced security and an investigation into the alleged leak of sensitive information. The threats, purportedly issued by a shadow group calling itself United Liberation Council, allegedly carries names, residential addresses and vehicle details of Kashmiri Pandit government employees. -PTI

Allahabad HC Dismisses Plea Seeking Permission to Wear Headscarf in School

PRAYAGRAJ: Allahabad High Court has dismissed a petition seeking direction to school authorities to permit the petitioner to wear a headscarf in addition to the uniform prescribed by the school. The petition was filed by a minor girl and a student of the Tagore Public School, Attarsuiya, Prayagraj, who has passed the high school and seeks admission to Class XI in the same institution. A two-judge bench observed: "We have perused photographs from various classes relating to the petitioner. Except for her, no other girl student is donning headscarf, even those belonging to the same religious community as the petitioner." -PTI

South Sudan: India Condemns Attack on UN Peacekeepers; 'Ensure Safety and Security'

UNITED NATIONS: India has condemned the attack on UN peacekeepers in South Sudan. "We condemn the attack carried out on UN peacekeepers deployed with UNMISS on 24 August 2026. We pay tribute to the fallen Ethiopian Blue Helmet and wish an early recovery to the injured peacekeepers," the Permanent Mission of India to the UN said in a social media post. India reiterated the fundamental importance of respecting the sanctity and inviolability of UN premises and personnel. "We call upon all parties to ensure the safety and security of UN peacekeepers, who operate under UN Security Council mandates," the mission said. -PTI

SEEKS MINISTER'S OUSTER

Combative BJP Stages Overnight Dharna in Assembly

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: The BJP on Monday stepped up its confrontation with the state government, announcing an overnight dharna inside the Assembly and demanding the removal of planning & statistics minister B Nagendra over the alleged Maharshi Valmiki ST Development Corporation scam.

The Opposition, which has disrupted Assembly proceedings for several days, entered the well of the House along with JD(S) MLAs and prevented the government from transacting legislative business.

Nagendra is facing an Enforcement Directorate money-laundering case



BJP MLAs, MLAs and workers stage a protest demanding the resignation of minister B Nagendra in Bengaluru on Monday – PTI

arising from the alleged diversion of funds from the corporation, which implements welfare schemes for Scheduled Tribe communities.

Opposition leader R Ashoka alleged in the Assembly that Congress leaders had benefited from the alleged ₹187-crore scam and accused the

government of shielding Nagendra. The Congress government has rejected the Opposition's allegations.

Ashoka said the Opposition expected the government to take a decision on Nagendra's continuance in the Cabinet and questioned whether the government was willing to disrupt the functioning of the legislature to protect one minister.

Earlier in the day, BJP state president BY Vijayendra and Ashoka led party legislators in a protest outside Vidhana Soudha, demanding Nagendra's immediate removal.

The BJP and JD(S) have been protesting the minister's reinduction into the Cabinet, keeping the issue alive through the ongoing Assembly session.

The BJP had blocked legislative business for much of the previous week, allowing the government to conduct only limited proceedings.

Nagendra, the Ballari Rural MLA, resigned as Scheduled Tribes Welfare Minister in 2024 after allegations surfaced of the diversion of funds from the Valmiki corporation. He has denied wrongdoing and was re-inducted into the Cabinet in the recent expansion.

BILLS PASSED

The Legislative Council on Monday passed two bills amid Opposition protests — the Karnataka Municipalities (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and the Karnataka Apartment Ownership and Management Bill, 2026.



India Reaches Out to Russia with PM Modi's Letter to Prez Putin

Jaishankar discusses ways to boost defence, eco ties with Russian leaders

Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury



New Delhi: External affairs minister S Jaishankar Monday met Russian President Vladimir Putin and handed over a personal communication from Prime Minister Narendra Modi ahead of the two leaders' meetings in Bishkek and New Delhi in the coming few weeks and bilateral annual summit in Moscow later in the year.

In his opening remarks during his meeting with Putin at the Kremlin, Jaishankar said, "Let me begin by conveying the good wishes of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. He has given me a personal communication which I would like to hand over to you."

"We had a meeting of the Intergovernmental Commission," the minister said. "I think overall we have a good report to give to you. I think our economic cooperation, trade, energy, fertilisers, nuclear, and other dimensions as well, I'd be pleased to speak about them in detail."

"Overall, our economic cooperation has grown very significantly. PM Modi looks forward to meeting you at the SCO Summit, then welcoming you to India for the BRICS Summit, and, in due course, as per your mutual convenience, having the annual summit, so we have a very strong picture of cooperation to present," said Jaishankar.

In his opening remarks, Putin said, "Your visit today underscores the level of relations that has long been established between Russia and India, over decades."

"We continue to work together in virtually all areas... I know that you (EAM) and your Russian counterpart, Russian Deputy PM Manturov, who heads the Russian part of the intergovernmental commission, have already worked hard and have undoubtedly discussed the most important issues. There are many of them. One of these issues is not only energy – it is, of course, fertiliser supplies. We are doing everything to address this issue for Indian farmers, for agriculture; we are increasing these supplies and are ready to do so further."

Earlier, Jaishankar held high-level talks to boost defence and economic ties in preparation for Putin's visit to India next month for the BRICS Summit and bilateral meeting with Modi.

Put Mangaluru Rly Area Transfer on Hold: Satheesan to Modi

Thiruvananthapuram: Kerala chief minister VD Satheesan on Monday urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to put on hold the Railway Board's decision to transfer the Mangaluru area, including Ullal, from the Palakkad Division of Southern Railway to the Mysuru Division of South Western Railway from October 1.

In a letter, Satheesan sought the PM's "personal intervention" to reconsider the decision after consultations with the Kerala government and other stakeholders. Any jurisdictional reorganisation should be undertaken only after objectively assessing its impact on all the regions concerned, he said. **PTI**

Cauvery Dispute: SC Asks TN to Approach Water Authority for Proportionate Share

INTERSTATE ISSUE WILL COME UP FOR HEARING ON AUG 31

Earlier Observation

SC bench had earlier observed that TN appeared to have received more water than its allocated share from Karnataka

ment seeking directions to Karnataka for the immediate release of its due share of water.

Responding to the submission by Tamil Nadu's counsel that the state was not receiving its proportionate share of water, a division bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said it had previously observed that Tamil Nadu appeared to have received more water than its allocated share from Karnataka.

The bench on Monday pointed out that Tamil Nadu had already received water in accordance with the CWMA's directions.

However, Tamil Nadu's counsel contended that the CWMA had not directed the release of the proportionate quantity of water that the state was required to receive.

The court then asked Tamil Nadu to approach the CWMA on the issue. The matter will come up for resumed hearing on August 31.

DMK Cries Politics as Vijay Scraps Plan for Parandur Airport

Our Political Bureau

Chennai: The DMK and other opposition parties in the Tamil Nadu Assembly staged a walkout on Monday following the ruling TVK's decision to scrap the proposed Parandur greenfield airport project.

Some dissenting parties questioned whether the move was a political gimmick while the DMK accused the Speaker of suppressing opposition voices by denying time for discussion on the announcement.

Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay said the greenfield airport project had drawn strong opposition from farmers who did not wish to part with their land and declared that the project will be shelved.

The project had been conceived during the DMK regime. In protest over the government's decision, the DMK walked out saying that the state's interests cannot be "mortgaged for petty political considerations".

Expanded Free Bus Travel for Women in TN

Chennai: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday announced a series of welfare programmes in the state assembly, building on his electoral promises.

Vijay unveiled a scheme to provide free LPG cylinders for eligible families and expanded the free bus travel for women, while also extending the travel benefits to transgender persons. — **OPB**

Former chief minister MK Stalin termed the decision as an irreversible setback for Tamil Nadu's growth.

"The announcement made today by the chief minister of Tamil Nadu to drop the Parandur International Airport project will set the state's development back by several years," the DMK said.

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

Jarange Puts Aug 28 Deadline for Maha to Clear Quota Papers

Jalna: Maratha reservation activist Manoj Jarange on Monday remained firm on a hunger strike from August 29 at Antarwali Sarati in Jalna district, reiterating his demand for reservation for the Maratha community under the Other Backward Classes (OBC) category. A delegation comprising Maharashtra ministers Shambhuraj Desai, Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, and Uday Samant met Jarange and appealed to him not to proceed with the agitation. — **PTI**

Abhishek Moves SC for Early Decision on Pleas Against Rebels

New Delhi: Trinamool Congress general secretary and Lok Sabha leader Abhishek Banerjee has approached the Supreme Court seeking an expeditious decision by Speaker Om Birla on petitions seeking disqualification of 20 rebel party MPs who have aligned themselves with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joydalya Bagchi and V Mohana has listed the plea of Banerjee for hearing on August 25. — **PTI**



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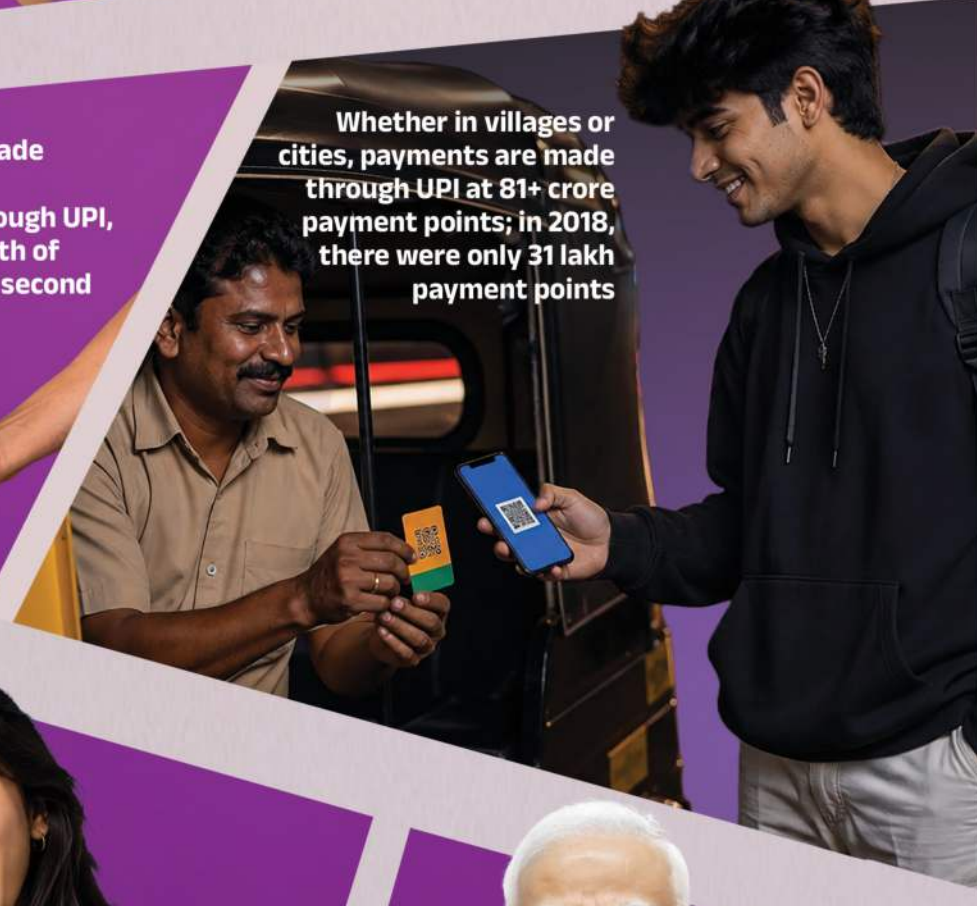
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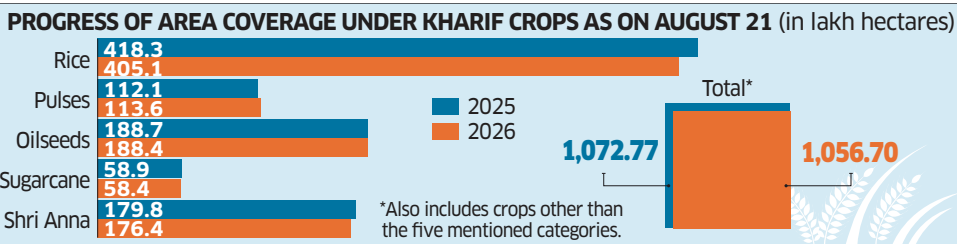
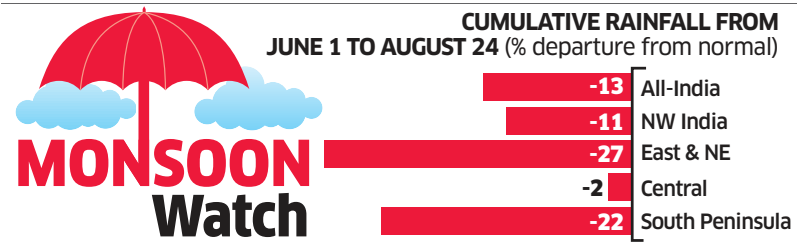
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Under the influence of low-pressure area over Gangetic West Bengal & adjoining Jharkhand and North Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh

Isolated heavy rainfall also likely over Bihar and Uttar Pradesh during next 3 to 4 days

Subdued rainfall activity likely to continue over Peninsular India during next one week

Source: IMD, Agriculture Ministry

In Brief

DP World Seeks Concession Period Extension at JNP

New Delhi: Dubai-based logistics major DP World is seeking an extension of the concession period of its Nhava Sheva International Container Terminal (NSICT) at Jawaharlal Nehru Port located near Mumbai, beyond the 30-year tenure ending 2027, a senior company official said on Monday. The concession period of NSICT, India's first private container terminal with a berth length of 600 metres and one of the five operating at Jawaharlal Nehru Port, ends on June 30, 2027, after a 30-year run. PTI

Banks Told to Have Stricter Norms For Eligibility of Forensic Auditors

PROBE UNDER PMLA Two audit firms de-empanelled from specialised monitoring list after adverse remarks in Amtek, ACIL cases

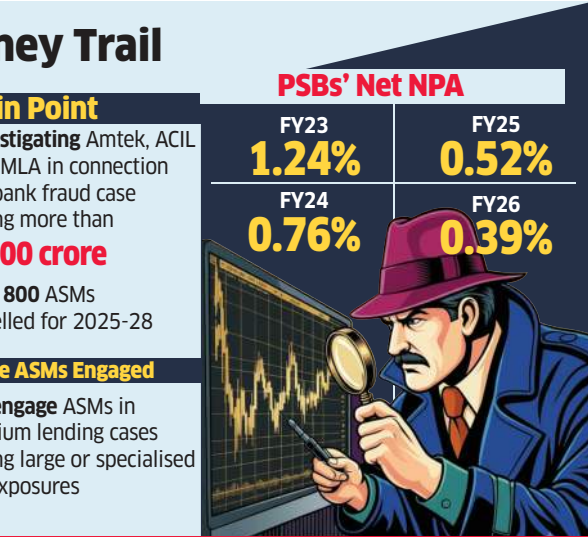
Dheeraj Tiwari

New Delhi: The government has directed banks to tighten the empanelment framework for forensic auditors by imposing stricter eligibility criteria following Enforcement Directorate (ED) observations against two audit firms in cases involving

RECORD PROFIT

Public sector banks posted a record net profit of ₹1.98 Lcrore in FY26

Amtek Group and ACIL Ltd. Banks have since de-empanelled the two auditors from their Agencies for Specialised Monitoring (ASM) list, said two executives aware of the developments. "The investigation agency had recommended immediate blacklisting of these audit firms and termination of ongoing engagements," said one of the executives, adding



that lenders will take further measures to review the framework for empanelment of audit firms. There are around 800 agencies, including chartered accountants, empanelled for specialised monitoring for the 2025-28 period.

Public sector banks posted a record net profit of ₹1.98 lakh crore in FY26, driven by improved asset quality, healthy credit growth and higher income, marking their fourth consecutive year of profitability.

Govt Lifts Restrictions on Wheat Exports



Our Bureau

Pune: India has moved wheat and wheat product exports from the prohibited to open category after four years. With global wheat prices rising due to geopolitical reasons, export demand for Indian wheat had increased from Bangladesh. However, only big players were able to take advantage of this export opportunity due to the export restrictions, said industry leaders. The Roller Flour Processors Federation of India said MSMEs will now be able to take their brand overseas. The Director General of Foreign Trade issued the notifications removing wheat and atta, maida, rava/suji from the prohibited to free category with immediate effect.

Air Passenger Prices Up 32%; Service PPI Trends Stay Divergent

Rly, insurance, telecom services see price rises, while banking and securities services decline

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Service prices showed a mixed trend in the first quarter of FY27, with airline, railway, insurance and telecom services seeing price increases, while securities transaction and banking services recorded declines, according to provisional data released by the ministry of commerce and industry on Monday.

The sharpest increase among the services tracked under the Service Producer Price Index (PPI) was in air passenger service prices, which rose 31.9% year-on-year (y-o-y) in the June quarter.

The Service PPI was introduced in June as part of the government's new Producer Price Index framework, with 2022-23 as the base year. It aims to measure price movements at the producer or service-provider level.

The index covers seven sectors, including banking, securities transactions, insurance, railways and telecom.

The government has not assigned weights to these sectors as they do not represent the entire services sector.

The increase in air passenger service prices for the earlier quarters has not been computed because FY26 has been used as the price reference period for compiling the index.

The Banking Service Contribution Index rose 6.9% y-o-y in the June quarter, up from 3.3% in the last quarter of FY26.

However, the Banking Service Price Index declined 3.5% compared with a 4.1% contraction in the earlier quarter.

During the quarter, the Management of Pension Funds Service Price Index increased 3.2% y-o-y. In the previous quarter, it had shown a contraction of 0.8%. The Insurance Service Price Index rose 1% y-o-y compared with 0.7% in the last quarter of FY26.

Within the railways sector, passenger service prices rose 3.5% in the first quarter of FY27, unchanged from the previous quarter, while freight service prices increased 0.1% compared with no change in the last quarter of FY26.

The Railway Service Price Index showed a 1.3% increase, up slightly from 1.2% in the previous quarter. Meanwhile, telecom service price inflation eased to 0.7% in the June quarter from 1% in Q4 of FY26. The Securities Transaction Service Price Index fell 1.3% in Q1 OF FY27, reversing a 0.6% increase recorded in the previous quarter.

Rain Check

- Service PPI was introduced in June as part of government's Producer Price Index framework
- It aims to measure price movements at the producer or service-provider level

Air Passenger Service Prices Up 31.9% yoy

Banking Service Contribution Index: Up 6.9% yoy

Management of Pension Funds Service Price Index: Up 5.2% yoy

Insurance Service Price Index: Up 1% yoy

Railway Service Price Index: Up 1.3% qoq (In June quarter)

SERVICE

After Sugar, Jaggery Prices Up 25%

Pune: After sugar, jaggery prices have surged about 25% in the past fortnight in key producing states of Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh, raising the cost of sweets for consumers ahead of the festive season.

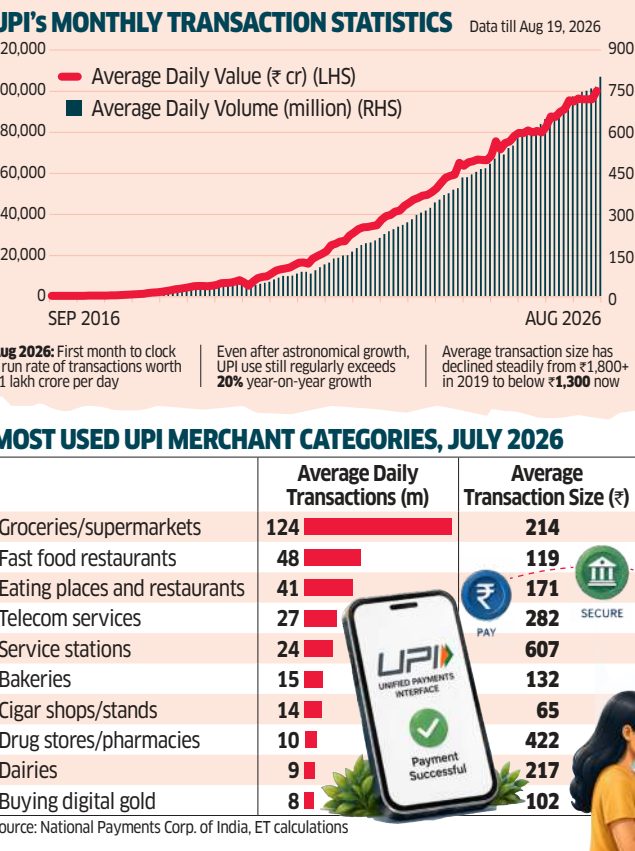
Prices are expected to remain firm until October, when fresh jaggery production begins, industry executives said.

A government crackdown on units in Maharashtra making adulterated jaggery has already tightened supplies over the past three months, adding to the pressure. With sugarcane availability expected to decline next year, jaggery prices could remain elevated through 2027, industry veterans said, extending the squeeze on sweet makers and consumers.

Jaggery prices, which move in tandem with sugar prices, shot up in August by 25-30% across the country, said manufacturers and traders. The top sugarcane producing states like Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh are also the jaggery producing states.

Jaggery prices in the wholesale markets have increased by ₹10-18/kg in the last two to three weeks. In Kolhapur, which produces the top quality jaggery in the country, prices have jumped by more than 25% in the last fortnight. —Jayashree Bhosale

UPI@10: A Miracle Story



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tender & notices

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NOTICE INVITING TENDER Tender No. RFQ_007_2026_SOCH
Within the scope of the National HIV Program of the National AIDS Control Organisation (NACO), several ART centres across the country are proposed to be equipped with Desktop Computers and measurement devices. Project SOCH- Strengthening Overall Care for HIV beneficiaries is being implemented by YRGMERF under the 2024-27 GRATM Cycle, to support the above Program of NACO. YRGMERF invites Bids for Desktop PCs with accessories, software licenses and electronic devices for supply & delivery to the ART Centres of National AIDS Control Organisation. Bids are to be presented to the generic E-Mail box: rfp@yrgcare.org Last date for submission of complete bids is: 10th September 2026. For complete details on this tender process including timeline and instructions on how to present your bids, please visit our website: https://www.yrgmerf.org/procurement-notice
All requests for clarification on the bid documents are to be addressed only in strict adherence to the instructions on the tender process set out in our bid document.

personal

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Nayan Ananth Kulkarni, D/o Ananth Kulkarni, residing at #106, J Block, Naraina Citadel Apartment, Akshaya Vana, Nobel Residency Road, Chandrashekarpuram, Begur Hobali, Bangalore - 560076, have changed my name to Nayan Kulkarni for all future intents and purposes vide Sworn Affidavit Dated 20/08/2026 executed before Notary R. Basavaraja at Bangalore

I Varalakshmi Thandav Murthy W/o Thandavamurthy Acharya, Born on 20/07/1971, Residing at Bangalore - 91, Bilikallu, Near D S M Apartment, Ullal main road, 10th Cross, No 38, Have Changed Name to Adaralakshmi Thandavamurthy Acharya, Vide Affidavit Dated 20/08/2026, Notary T.V.Bhadrajiyaya at Bangalore for all purposes.

I, Venkatesh Murthy G S/o Govindaraju R/o Thyamagondlu Hobli, VTC: Obalapura, PO: Obalapura, Dist-Bangalore Advertisements, have changed my minor daughter's name from Ruthvika V aged 1 year to Ruthu V forever.

I Pooja Kumari D/O, Kani Ram R/o A504 Shri Ram Suhana Apartment, Doddaballapur Road, opp Bmsit College, Yelahanka, Bangalore -560064 have changed my name to Pooja Goyal

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CHANGE OF NAME

I, Neha Jais W/o Deepak Kumar Sahu, residing at 708, Balaji Aavaas, Whitefield, Bangalore-560066, have changed my name to Neha Nareeshkumar Jais for all future purposes vide affidavit dated 22/08/2026 before Notary Veena J. Bangalore.

I, Shinder Kaur, M/o, 14862908W-Sep/MT-Gurwinder Singh, R/o, Alpanada Kalan, Patiala, Punjab, changed name to Sinder Kaur, for all purpose.

I, Umesh Pandit S/o Chandra dev, R/o- Ward 11 Shivnagar Muzaffara Panapur Birpur Begusarai Bihar- 851127, have changed the name of my Minor Son Harinarayana Kumar Alias Harinarayan Pandit Aged 14 Years and he shall Hereafter be known as Harinarayan Pandit.

I Sumitra M W/o Ravikumar K, R/o No 23, Akshaya Dham, 4th Cross, Nagenahalli, Singanayakanahalli Post, Yelahanka, Bengaluru-560064. I have Changed my name from Sumitra M to Sumithra M for all purposes.

LOST & FOUND

NOTICE OF LOST PASSPORTS Notice is hereby given that Yemeni Passports belonging to Ammar Moqbel Saleh Abo-Ehryg (Passport No: 12682985) and Saleh Mohammed Naji Al-Maleki (Passport no.13001189) have been lost in Bangalore on 14 August 2026. A formal police report has been filed. Any person finding these passports is kindly requested to return them to the nearest police station or call us on 9108040150

New Rules in Two Months to Address Chip, Auto Parts Cos' Concerns: Goyal

Govt has simplified BIS framework; is working to ease approval process, says Goyal

Kirtika Suneja

Tokyo: India will amend regulations and introduce new rules within two months to address concerns raised by semiconductor and automotive component manufacturers, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday.

In a fireside chat with Nikkei Asia in Tokyo, the minister said he met two companies seeking to bring semiconductor and auto-component manufacturing



Union commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal at a round-table meeting with the Japan Business Federation in Tokyo. ANI

to India and that their concerns were resolved during the discussions. He also rejected the idea of India being viewed merely as a "plus-one" destination. "I have assured them that within the next two months, India will amend its regulations, bring in new rules to accommodate their request and ensure

that they will have absolutely no problem as they bring manufacturing into India," he said. Goyal explained that the government has significantly simplified the Bureau of Indian Standards framework and is working to ease the approval process, including for suppliers that may not be covered under the revised regulations.

Industry Wants Assured Offtake for Coal Gasification

FUTURE IN SMOKE? Without guaranteed buyers, private firms remain reluctant to commit large capex

Prashant Mukherjee

New Delhi: The The energy industry is seeking assured offtake commitments from the government for coal gasification projects, arguing that viability gap funding (VGF) alone may not be enough to unlock investments in capital-intensive plants. The investment case remains weak even with government support, if project developers have to commit thousands of crores without certainty on demand, on who would buy the gasification output and at what volumes and prices, industry executives said. "If you are putting in

₹10,000 crore and there is no assured place to sell the output, the arithmetic does not work," a senior industry executive told ET.

Coal gasification is a process that converts solid coal into synthetic gas, which has multiple uses. The com-

ments come as the government rolls out a ₹37,500 crore incentive scheme aimed at scaling up surface coal and lignite gasification and building a domestic coal-to-chemicals ecosystem. The industry is also seeking freight support or allo-

cation of land near the mine head and ports for gasification projects supplying fertiliser and steel plants, saying logistics costs could further weaken the economics of these projects. While the new scheme provides

a financial incentive of up to 20% of the cost of plant and machinery, industry executives said a capital subsidy alone would not address demand and market risks associated with projects that need large up-front investments and have long gestation periods.

The experience of the Talcher fertiliser project in Odisha has highlighted some of the execution challenges associated with coal gasification. The project, being implemented by Talcher Fertilizers Ltd—a joint venture of state-run Gail India, Coal India, Rashtriya Chemicals & Fertilizers and Fertilizers Corporation of India—is designed to

produce about 1.27 million tonnes of urea a year using coal gasification. The project has seen delays and increase in its estimated cost, with its commissioning timeline now pushed to December 2027. The project cost increased to ₹19,000 crore as January this year, compared with the initial estimate of ₹13,500 crore. Without long-term purchase agreements, private players remain reluctant to fund the remaining 80% capex, putting India's target of gasifying 100 million tonnes of coal by 2030 at risk. Unlike renewable power, synthetic gas lacks a mandatory procurement policy to de-risk debt.

Caught In a Haze

Coal Gasification
This is a process that converts solid coal into synthetic gas



Govt Package
Government has rolled out a ₹37,500-crore incentive scheme
It is aimed at scaling up surface coal and lignite gasification
Also to build a domestic coal-to-chemicals ecosystem

Industry Demand
Industry is seeking freight support or allocation of land near mine heads and ports for gasification projects supplying fertiliser and steel plants
This is to save on logistics costs



ANIMISHA

Less Chips Chipping Away at AIInfra?

Nvidia's server price hike signals rising costs

Nvidia is reportedly planning to increase the price of servers containing AI chips — some customers being told of an increase of more than 15% — due to a global shortage of memory and storage chips that is likely to extend beyond 2027. The surge in prices of semiconductors is being fuelled by AI hyperscalers. Chipmakers Samsung, Micron and SK Hynix have pivoted to producing more AI-grade chips than those that go into consumer electronics. They are setting up new capacities. However, semiconductor fabrication plants take years to build, and new production is unlikely to come on stream until late 2028. Export restrictions and supply chain diversion are adding to complexity by delaying the distribution of chip-making machinery.

Nvidia will be joining a growing list of technology companies like Apple and Microsoft in failing to hold their product price lines because of the chronic shortage of chips. Advanced chips made by Nvidia are subject to US export controls, and the additional cost of its servers should have a bearing on how the AI race is being run. AI companies are running into energy and compute constraints as they intensify their infra buildup. They are also facing resistance from local communities over resource requirements of data centres. Rising costs of server farms will raise the capital intensity of training, deploying and scaling AI models. These costs will be transferred to client enterprises that are coming to grips with the sticker shock of AI.

Some estimates say the chip shortage could extend until the end of the decade, with demand accelerating for AI solutions. By 2030, businesses will have shifted from basic AI bots to multi-agent systems embedded in global supply chains. About 1/3rd of current work hours could be automated over the next 5 yrs, requiring enormous investment in AI infrastructure. As the world's most valuable company — north of \$5 tn — Nvidia holds a special place in this ecosystem, and its ability to absorb the rise in semiconductor prices will determine the pace of AI infrastructure growth.



Don't Tamper With Kaziranga's Buffer

Assam's proposal, a 1-3 km site-specific eco-sensitive zone (ESZ) around Kaziranga National Park and Tiger Reserve — instead of the default 10 km extent — is not just about numbers. A smaller ESZ could cut off the park from its wider landscape, turning it into an island fortress with disastrous consequences for its wildlife, particularly during the June-September monsoon months, when its fluvial plains are inundated by floodwaters from the Brahmaputra.

Ironically, it was the 2017 floods, which killed over 100 animals trapped in Kaziranga, that highlighted the need for a landscape conservation approach with dedicated animal corridors to facilitate movement. Assam's proposal risks turning NH-715 into a hard, functional wall between the park and landscape. While an ESZ is not a no-activity area, it is regulated. Taking the highway out of the regulated zone could lead to a spike in traffic flows. This would make it more dangerous for animals as they move to the higher ground of the Karbi-Anglong hills during the flood season.

Repercussions for tourism revenues will follow. Gate-entry fees accrue ₹88 mn a year. More broadly, the economic value and ecological benefits of an intact Kaziranga landscape have been estimated at ₹9.8 bn in annual ecosystem service flows, nearly ₹1 bn in stock assets, including carbon storage, apart from the costs of impaired hydrological functions.

The expert committee reviewing the proposal must undertake an impact assessment and wide public consultation before offering its advice to the environment ministry. A landscape approach to conservation, rooted in science and economics, has been government policy since 2017. The ministry must not let a narrower boundary produce a narrower vision of conservation.



JUST IN JEST

Forget FOMO, missing out, dear reader, is the new keeping up

Oh, for JOMO, the Joy of Missing Out!

In today's economy of hyper-attention, where every ping is a summons and every calendar a battlefield, a delicious luxury has emerged: Jomo, a.k.a. Joy of Missing Out. Unlike its fretful cousin Fomo, which drives otherwise sane people to weddings they barely recall and events they barely understand, Jomo is the art of staying back with smug serenity. Why endure a 3-hr networking event when one can cultivate one's exclusive network by not being there? The true power broker is the one whose absence is felt more keenly than their presence. Jomo is the invisible hand of social life, guiding the market of invitations by declining them.

Economists might call it opportunity cost inverted: the gain of not spending time badly. Psychologists hail it as mindfulness with a dash of mischief. The rest of us simply relish the guilty pleasure of slippers over stilettos. The joy lies not merely in missing out but in knowing that others are enduring the speeches, the PPTs, the traffic jams — while you are luxuriating in another episode of another season. In a world obsessed with productivity, Jomo is the ultimate contrarian investment: a portfolio of peace, yielding dividends of sanity. The next time your phone buzzes with an invitation, consider the chic-est RSVP of all: a polite decline, followed by a grin. Missing out, dear reader, is the new keeping up.

India-US ties are looking up, but the Russia and Iran sanctions bill, FCRA, & BRICS will test reset GIVE IT ANOTHER SHOT?



Seema Sirohi

US-India relations have improved since last year's tariff onslaught and political troubles. Activity at the functional level is substantial, especially in the defence arena with a new 10-yr framework agreement signed and sale of anti-tank Javelin missiles underway. Indian exports to the US grew by 5.5%, reaching nearly \$60 bn in the first 9 mths of FY26.

But there's trouble too. Delhi doesn't have a real sense of what the contours of US policy are towards India, especially after a top State Department official publicly declared in March that the US would not 'make the same mistakes with India that we made with China 20 years ago... let you develop all these markets and then the next thing we know you're beating us in a lot of commercial things.' The statement lit a spark, and everyone was ready to believe the worst.

No surprise that Delhi got busy wooing other partners, creating extra geopolitical options for itself. But the basic premise remains: the US is a crucial partner. The Indian establishment is careful not to use fighting words or engage in a tit-for-tat. Meanwhile, Donald Trump is bogged down in a war that he can't end, a shaky bond market, a \$40 tn debt, and a looming midterm election that's making Republicans nervous.

Three unrelated developments may create further complications in this somewhat uncertain phase in US-India relations:

- Sweeping Russia and Iran sanctions bill, which has bipartisan support and targets India, China and three others. First introduced in April 2025, it calls for 100% tariffs on the 5 top buyers of Russian oil. It got a fillip after its original proponent Lindsey Graham died last month.
- The bill soon cleared the Senate with an 86-11 vote. Both Dems and Republicans used Graham's demise to pressure the White House, whose main occupant is not a natural Russia critic, as the rest of political Washington. The bill must still go through the House before being signed into law by the president.
- Trump is believed not to be particularly enthusiastic about using the lever. He knows putting 100% tariffs on Chinese exports would trigger an equal and opposite reaction from Beijing. Besides, Xi Jinping is expected in DC on Sep 24, and a lot is riding on the visit. In other words, the bill may be held in abeyance.
- India's Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), which has riled up both Republicans and Democrats. This has been kicked down the road.



Hunuz DC door ast, Sergio Gor at Pari Mahal, Srinagar

The Modi government has sent the controversial Act to a joint parliamentary committee after criticism from Opposition leaders and a couple of US lawmakers that it targets particular religious groups. The Act will get a second look. But don't expect an overhaul — a majority of MPs in the 31-member committee are from the ruling coalition.

India's ambassador Vinay Kwatra recently made a rare intervention on X earlier this month to debunk the 'myth' that FCRA would cut foreign funding to civil society organisations. Foreign money flows to registered entities have been rising, and places of worship have an additional layer of protection in case their registration is cancelled. Their assets can be transferred to another FCRA-compliant group of the same faith, he stressed.

In any case, the US has its version of registration and compliance for foreign entities, as do Australia, Britain and Canada. As always, US domestic politics and constituent pressure will determine the level of hypocrisy when dealing with another country. Christian groups are a vocal, powerful voting bloc.

- The upcoming BRICS summit in Delhi, which works as a magnet for negative attention

in Trump's world. The president has a visceral dislike of the grouping. He's convinced it's a rogues' gallery designed to undermine US dominance and the dollar. A group photo of Modi with Iranian president Masoud Pezeshkian, Vladimir Putin and Xi in Delhi could set him off, with attendant courtiers stoking the fire, even though Trump has hosted the Russian president and is about to welcome the Chinese leader.

His energetic envoy, Sergio Gor, will try to deflect. But he can't change Trump's fundamentals. Gor is doing his best to shift the US-India dynamics from political stasis to political excitement, travelling from Kerala to Kashmir. So, is he travelling more because he finds 'Hunuz Dilli door ast' and preoccupied with other ventures?

Gor's recent statement on Kashmir being 'an important part of India' got significant attention. It was



Trump has a visceral dislike of BRICS. He's convinced it's a rogues' gallery designed to undermine US dominance and the dollar

designed to. The visit wasn't innocent just as Marco Rubio's visit to Mother Teresa's Missionaries of Charity in Kolkata in May wasn't.

But reading too much into a word is folly, especially when every part of India by definition is 'important' for the people and the state. The word 'important' falls comfortably between anodyne and provocative.

If Gor meant business, he would have said Kashmir is an 'integral' part of India. Reality is that US ambassadors visit both sides of Kashmir when they find it necessary to curry favour with their hosts, or send a signal. Gor's visit and words were a positive signal to Delhi, no doubt. But they do not represent a major shift. If anything, his boss remains enthralled by the field marshal next door:



Gor's statement on Kashmir being 'an important part of India' got significant attention. But reading too much into a word is folly — 'important' falls comfortably between anodyne and provocative

Add More Fuel to Agniveers



Kamal Davar

One prominent measure, touted as a major transformative effort in the armed forces, was introduction of the Agniveer scheme in 2022, ostensibly for the three services to improve their age profile. Since its inception, the scheme was beset with differing views regarding duration of service, pay structure and other issues. In the last 2 yrs, GoI took stock, and is now reportedly listening to the views of not only the three services but also of state governments and veterans. So, here goes one.

The Agniveer scheme as part of the Agnipath programme was launched for young Indians of both genders aged 17.5-21 yrs for a 4-yr service tenure in the three services. They were to have a salary of ₹30,000 a month, rising to ₹40,000 in their last year of service. Adequate medical and insurance provision arrangements were also ensured.

On completion of 4 yrs of service, they would receive a tax-free Seva Nidhi package of ₹11.71 lakh. 25% of Agniveers (likely to be raised to 50%) would be back in the armed forces, and be entitled to the same scales of pay and allowances and other terms of service as regular members in the army.

As of now, after their 4 yrs of service as Agniveers, several states and central organisations provide prioritised horizontal reservations (10-20%) for Agniveers in state police forces and paramilitary units like CRPF, BSF and CISE. Disaster management forces, forest and firefighting departments in several states also have earmarked job quotas for former Agniveers.

One of the reasons considered by many analysts for GoI having taken this step is to reduce the burgeoning

defence revenue bill. No matter the veracity of this point of view, there are many other ways to trim budgets, including drastically reducing the many civilian appointments in the defence ministry.

GoI could consider appointing a high-powered committee to go into the entire gamut of measures to reduce defence expenditure. Adequate capital and revenue expenditure for security imperatives has to be ensured in these challenging times. So, cutting down on recruitment of soldiers will just not be prudent. According to some media reports, Indian Army is over a lakh soldiers deficient.

An important reason to eliminate the ceiling of a 4-yr limit tenure for soldiers is that this period does not give adequate time for them to master their soldierly skills. This problem gets further accentuated when it comes to handling technical arms, with hi-tech weaponry skills often taking years to master.

Fighting prowess of the forces is also greatly dependent on the morale, motivation and the unit spirit of its soldiers. This spirit takes many years to cultivate and imbibe before it becomes a battle-winning factor. So, time is needed for any young recruit to become a highly motivated and skilful soldier for his or her unit.

GoI should modify the scheme suitably to give Agniveers at least 8 yrs in active service, and retention be upped to 50-75% from the present 25%.



You gotta step up

The writer is former director general, Defence Intelligence Agency (DIA), GoI

E20 Ain't Sugar's Only Villain



Nirmal Ganguly

All-India average retail price of sugar rose from ₹48.18 a kg on July 20 to ₹55.70 on August 20, an increase of about 16% in 1 mth. The immediate temptation is to blame ethanol and E20. But the story is more complicated.

Industry estimates suggest around 3 mn tonnes of sugar-equivalent output were diverted to ethanol in the 2025-26 season. That does not mean 3 mn tonnes of sugarcane land was shifted from food to fuel. Farmers do not grow separate cane for sugar and ethanol. The same cane can be processed into either at the mill.

However, when cane juice, syrup or molasses goes into ethanol, less sugar becomes available for human consumption. But the figure should be properly described. The 3 mn tonne estimate is an industry estimate, not a figure issued by the consumer affairs ministry.

At first sight, there appears to be a contradiction in GoI's position. It has rejected the suggestion that ethanol diversion is responsible for the sugar price surge. It has also stated that the share of sugar diverted to ethanol declined from around 12% in 2022-23 to about 9% in 2025-26. Yet, industry estimates put the absolute diversion at around 3 mn tonnes. Moreover, India's ethanol feedstock has changed, with GoI stating that nearly 3/4th of ethanol now comes from grains, particularly maize.

Importantly, ethanol diversion exists and matters. But the evidence does not establish it as the principal cause of the current sugar-price surge. According to GoI's August 21 statement, sugar production in October 2025-September 2026 is now expected to be around 306 LMT, compared with the initial estimate of about 343 LMT. The shortfall of about 37 LMT is substantial.

GoI attributes the weaker production to crop damage, and waterlogging caused by excessive rainfall. Then comes demand. India's festival season brings a predictable hike in demand for sugar, sweets and gur. When supply is tight, even normal seasonal demand can have an unusually large effect on prices.

Moreover, international sugar prices have risen, while global supplies have tightened. This affects the economics of domestic stocks, exports and imports.

GoI's decision to permit 10 LMT of duty-free raw-sugar imports, an unusual step after many years, is significant. It indicates that policymakers are dealing with a broader supply-and-inventory problem, not simply an ethanol problem.

There is also the possibility of stockholding and speculative behaviour: If traders and bulk consumers expect prices to rise further, they may hold stocks rather than release them. GoI's decision to impose stock limits and undertake physical verification reflects this concern.

The food-vs-fuel issue becomes even more interesting when we move from sugar to maize.

Maize has become an increasingly important ethanol feedstock. But it is also a major ingredient in poultry feed, accounting for roughly 55% of poultry-feed formulations. Greater demand from ethanol distilleries can, therefore, compete with poultry producers for maize and push up feed costs.

Soybean meal creates another pressure point. It is an important protein component of poultry feed, and weaker soybean availability has also increased its price. The result is visible in the egg market.

The chain is straightforward: higher maize and soybean costs mean higher poultry feed costs, means higher production costs, means higher egg and chicken prices. But again, ethanol is only one factor: Heat stress, poultry mortality, weather conditions and cost of imported feed ingredients also affect production and prices.

Newer vehicles designed and certified for E20 can use the blend. But many older vehicles were designed for E10 or below. Higher ethanol blends can raise concerns about the long-term compatibility and durability of certain fuel-system components in vehicles not designed for them.

There is also a fuel-efficiency issue. Ethanol contains less energy per litre than petrol. So, higher blends can require more fuel to travel the same distance, although the actual effect varies by vehicle and engine design. So, for consumers, cost of E20 can extend beyond the pump price.

Which is why chief economic adviser V Anantha Nageswaran's recent intervention is important. He suggested retaining an E10 option alongside E20 for older vehicles, and called for greater attention to the food-vs-fuel and water trade-offs before moving beyond E20. This does not require abandoning ethanol. It requires asking better questions: how much ethanol should India blend? From which feedstocks? At what agricultural and water cost? And under what food-supply conditions?

India needs a flexible feedstock strategy, greater use of agricultural residues and advanced biofuels, and closer coordination between energy, agriculture and food policy. The present sugar-price episode should neither become an argument for blindly defending E20 nor for blaming E20 for everything that has gone wrong.

Whisper sweet somethings

The writer is former adviser, Asian Development Bank



Few Mins of Nothingness

Multi-tasking is considered a great virtue both at the workplace and at home. You are watching a show on television even as you prep dinner. You go for a walk and simultaneously listen to a loaded discourse on happiness. You are driving and, at the same time, spelling out the day's schedule to your voice recorder. At the office meeting, you secretly scroll your phone under the table. You grab a quick lunch while catching up with missed phone calls or you eat while you finish writing that story on your laptop. Rush, rush, rush. Busy, busy, busy. At the end of the day, you are exhausted and, yet, sleep eludes you as you worry about what you have to do the next day. You dream of the holiday that will take you away from all this hectic activity; you wish to laze on a beach or trek up a hill. Maybe, then, you will get recharged and return rejuvenated. Sounds familiar?

Here's a workable solution, offers Pooja Bedi, who suggests you take a 5-min holiday every day, without having to go to Goa or Nepal. The holiday you've been craving is not about the sea or mountains, she says. It is all about taking a small break to be with yourself, doing nothing. 'I made myself a cup of tea. And instead of drinking it while answering messages,... I carried it outside, sat in a patch of sun and did absolutely nothing. No phone, podcast or some productive little work. I just felt the warmth on my face and saw light move through the leaves. Five minutes. When I came back inside, I felt I had been somewhere....'



The Devils Of Loudun

Aldous Huxley

When Voltaire went to school, the Jesuit colleges were familiar features of the educational scene. A century earlier, their merits had seemed positively revolutionary. In an age when most pedagogues were amateurs in everything except the handling of the birch, their disciplinary methods were relatively humane and their professors carefully chosen and systematically trained.

They taught a peculiarly elegant Latin and the very latest in optics, geography and mathematics, together with 'dramatics' (their end-of-term theatricals were famous), good manners, respect for the Church and (in France, at least, and after Henri IV's conversion) obedience to the royal authority.

For all these reasons, the Jesuit colleges recommended themselves to every member of the typical upper-class family — to the tender-hearted mother, who could not bear to think of her darling undergoing the tortures of an old-fashioned education; to the learned ecclesiastical uncle, with his concern for sound doctrine and a Ciceronian style; and finally to the father who, as a patriotic official, approved of monarchical principles and, as a prudent bourgeois, counted on the Company's backstairs influence to help their pupil to a job, a place at court, an ecclesiastical sinecure.

Chat Room

Penny Wise, Pound Wiser

Apologies 'The Long and Winding R&D' by Meenakshi Munshi and Pragya Chaube (Aug 22), a clear visibility of RoI is crucial for the investor and the beneficiary. The responsibility for this rests with both: the investor demanding it, and the beneficiary furnishing it. Since various national funding agencies would have diverse objectives in extending the funding, it is likely that some of the interim goals are pursued by multiple researchers funded by different agencies. Integrating the tracking of diverse funds and mapping each to a specific granular objective through UPMs is an excellent suggestion. With a sparse expenditure of 0.64% of GDP for R&D against 3-6% by comparable economies, India must have an overarching body for rigorous monitoring of every rupee spent without putting the burden of this on researchers and funding agencies. Prasad Ambadas Kulkarni Mumbai

INSIDE THE MIX Equity funds retain their dominance in SIP assets, accounting for 87% of total AUM; Hybrid and passive fund categories also draw good investment flows

Investors' Equity Rush Helps SIP Assets Triple in Five Years

Systematic Rally				
Year End	Annual SIP contribution (₹ cr)	Outstanding SIP accounts (cr)	SIP AUM (% of total MF AUM)	MF Industry AUM (₹ lakh cr)
Mar-21	0.89	3.72	13.50	31.4
Mar-22	1.25	5.27	15.20	37.6
Mar-23	1.56	6.36	17.20	39.4
Mar-24	1.99	8.40	19.90	53.4
Mar-25	2.89	10.05	20.10	65.7
Mar-26	3.50	10.44	20.10	73.7

SOURCE: AMFI data, AMFI Crisil Factbook 2026



Our Bureau

Mumbai: Systematic investment plans (SIPs) have grown steadily over the past five years as more investors have entered mutual funds and increased their exposure to equities. The number of unique mutual fund investors rose from 2.3 crore in March 2021 to 6.14 crore in March 2026, according to the AMFI-Crisil Intelligence report. Over the same period, SIP assets under management (AUM) more than tripled to ₹14.83 lakh crore

from ₹4.5 lakh crore. SIPs now account for 20.1% of the mutual fund industry's total AUM, up from 13.5% five years ago. Equity funds continue to dominate SIP investments, accounting for 87% of total SIP AUM, a share that has remained broadly stable over the past five years. Equity SIP AUM increased to ₹12.85 lakh crore from ₹3.46 lakh crore during this period. Other categories have also seen an increase. Hybrid SIP AUM rose to ₹1.11 lakh crore from ₹0.33 lakh crore, while passive SIP AUM increased to ₹0.46 lakh crore from ₹0.03 lakh crore.

India's Weight in EM ETFs Rises Again

Stronger performance relative to peers lifts weight but may not signal fresh ETF inflows

Sachin Kumar & Jaikishan Yadav

ET Intelligence Group: India's weight in the major global emerging-market Exchange Traded Funds (ETFs) has started to recover after declining steadily over the past year, shows the data from Bloomberg. The country's weight in the top 20 global emerging-market ETFs by assets has risen by five-to-116 basis points since the end of June 2026.

India's stable performance com-

FLOW REVERSAL



The inflow by foreign portfolio investors (FPI) has turned positive since July after a bout of outflows in the previous four months

Gaining Ground

India's allocation in top ETFs by assets (%)

	Aug 18, 2026	Jun 30, 2026	BPS change
iShares MSCI Emerging Markets ex China	14.6	13.5	115.8
Amundi MSCI Emerging Ex China UCITS	14.8	13.7	112.8
Xtrackers MSCI Emerging Markets UCITS	12.3	11.3	99.0
iShares MSCI Emerging Markets Min Vol Factor	16.2	15.3	88.7
iShares ESG Aware MSCI Emerging Markets Index	10.2	9.4	80.6
iShares Core MSCI Emerging Markets	12.7	12.1	64.0
iShares MSCI Emerging Markets	11.5	10.9	58.9
Amundi Core MSCI Emerging Markets UCITS	11.6	11.1	58.3
HSBC MSCI EMERGING MARKETS UCITS	11.6	11.0	57.4
Amundi Core MSCI Emerging Markets Swap UCITS	11.7	11.1	56.5

Bps: Basis points (100 bps= One percentage point) SOURCE: Bloomberg



pared with weakness in markets such as South Korea and Taiwan has increased its weight in the underlying indices. This is in contrast with the trend seen during the 12 months to June 30, 2026 when the country's weight in the sample ETFs declined by 540-to-998 basis points.

The increase, however, does not necessarily signal fresh ETF flows into India. Most of these funds track MSCI or other emerging-market benchmarks, which means changes in the relative performance of countries can alter their India allocation. Among the top 20 global ETFs by

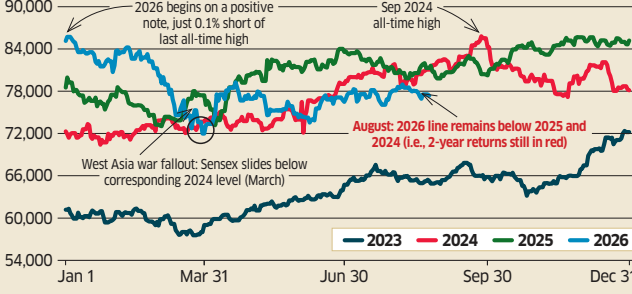
assets, the iShares MSCI Emerging Markets Ex China ETF registered the biggest increase in India's weight at 116 basis points, followed by 113 basis points rise in the Amundi MSCI Emerging Ex China UCITS ETF and 99 basis point increase in the Xtrackers MSCI Emerging Markets UCITS ETF.

RETURNS STAY NEGATIVE OVER ONE-, TWO-YEAR PERIODS

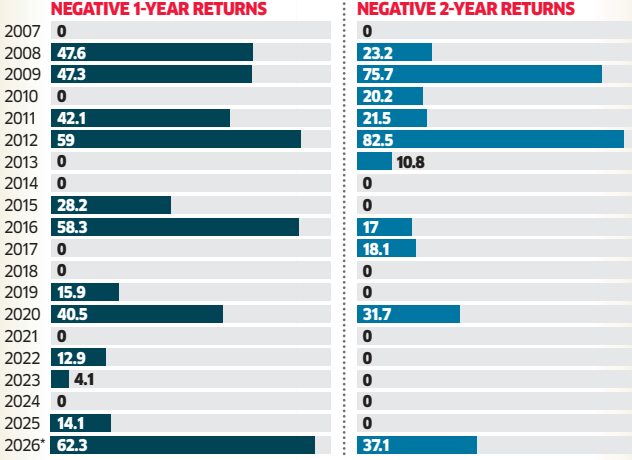
The Long Lull: 697 Days Without a New High

It's not often that India's stock markets disappoint investors for a long stretch. The benchmark indices have yielded negative returns not just over the past one year, but also over a two-year time-frame. In 2026, the Sensex has ended 37% of its trading days with two-year returns in red, the worst showing since 2012, shows an ET analysis. It's now 697 days, and counting, since the indices struck a new all-time high. **Tanay Sukumar** looks at the data:

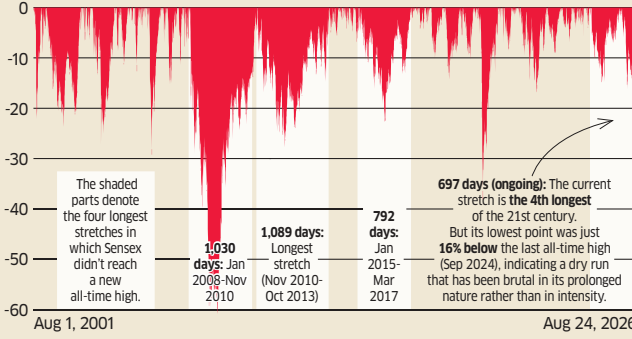
SENSEX, DAILY CLOSING VALUES, SINCE 2023



% OF TRADING DAYS WHEN SENSEX CLOSED WITH:



SENSEX, DAILY % GAP SINCE THE MOST RECENT ALL-TIME HIGH



Source: BSE, ET analysis

ALLEGED LOSS OF ₹3,912 CR

Sebi Drops Proceedings in Case Against Max, Axis Cos

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has dropped proceedings against Max Financial Services, Max Life Insurance Company, Axis Bank and other Axis group entities, concluding that allegations of disclosure lapses and a fraudulent scheme that allegedly caused a ₹3,912-crore loss to Max Financial and its shareholders couldn't be proved. The market regulator has also cleared Max Financial founder Analjit Singh, besides former and current senior executives named in the proceedings.

The case stems from Sebi's probe into a series of transactions between Max Financial, Max Life, and Axis entities between FY10 and FY22. The regulator had examined three sets of arrangements—in 2010, 2015 and 2020—relating to the issue, sale and subsequent acquisition of shares in Max Life.

Following the investigation, Sebi issued a show cause notice on October 24, 2024 alleging that the transactions were structured to provide Axis Bank benefits beyond permissible commission limits for its role as a corporate agent. It had also alleged that Max Financial made inadequate and delayed disclosures and that the arrangements formed part of a fraudulent scheme that benefited Axis entities at the expense of Max Financial and its shareholders.

"...the disclosures made by MFSL (Max Financial Services) could undoubtedly have been more comprehensive and, in certain instances, a more cautious and consistent approach to disclosure may have been desirable," said Sebi whole time member Amarjeet Singh.

TOI

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INSTANT SETTLEMENT

India Plans to Launch First Tokenised Bond in Sept

Reuters

Mumbai: India will launch tokenised corporate bonds next month, as it tests the use of blockchain technology to enable instant settlement of bond transactions, three sources with direct knowledge of the matter said on Monday. The notes, to be issued for the first time by state-owned power financier REC, would place India alongside markets such as Europe and Hong Kong in using the technology for issuance and settlement. Tokenised bonds are securities whose ownership, issuance, trading and settlement are recorded digitally on a blockchain or distributed ledger, allowing transactions to be completed almost instantly.

India's markets regulator and central bank are working together on pushing the technology, according to the sources, who spoke on the condition of anonymity as the discussions are ongoing and confidential.

REC will issue tokenised bonds worth less than 5 billion rupees (\$57 million) in the offering, the sources said. The offering is expected to be unveiled at an annual financial technology event in Mumbai next month, one of the sources said. India's central bank digital currency will be used to buy the tokenised bonds, one of the sources said.

Details about the issuer, timeline and framework have not been reported previously. "The offering would be made available to only a select group of investors at the pilot stage," one of the sources said. Reuters could not ascertain the names of the investors.

The central bank, markets regulator and REC did not respond to emails seeking comment.

NEW BOND FRAMEWORK

To tap the bonds, investors will need to access two digital accounts: a wholesale digital currency wallet provided by a bank, and a new electronic securities wallet, the sources said.

Indian depositories are developing an e-wallet, a first of its kind, called DEMAT 2.0, which will record bond holdings on a distributed ledger technology chain.

No Launches Yet



►► From Page 1

These include GEO, medium and low earth orbit satellites with terrestrial fixed and mobile networks like 4G/5G.

It is the latest addition to the list of India's satcom aspirants, which include Elon Musk's Starlink, Jeff Bezos-run Amazon Leo, Reliance Jio, and Bharti Group-backed Eutelsat OneWeb, which plan to offer the service using low earth orbit satellites.

Starlink alone has about 11,000 of them. None of the applicants have been able to launch services in India because of lack of security clearance, undecided spectrum pricing and a tussle over regulations with traditional telecom operators.

Notably, Starlink recently reapplied to the Indian government for authorisation for its Gen2 LEO constellation, which has the capability to offer direct-to-device services.

India's space economy is reckoned to have a potential to touch \$44 billion by 2033, boosting its global share to 8% from 2% currently, per estimates.

Singtel is currently providing broadcasting satellite capacity to a DTH operator in India, for which it has the requisite approval, the first person said.

The company offers global end-to-end fixed satellite communication services. The product and services offered under satellite segment include transponder lease, teleport hosting, satellite broadcast, VSAT service as well as low latency connectivity by Starlink, per Singtel's website.

The second person said Singtel has made sizeable investments in the space segment, particularly to support its plans for India. "India is going to be the primary market for Singtel's space ambitions," the first person said.

Jefferies raises forecast to \$90-100 b by August 31 as banks tap strong overseas demand

Full Flow FCNR Deposits Could Hit \$100 Billion, Beat Estimates

Joel Rebello

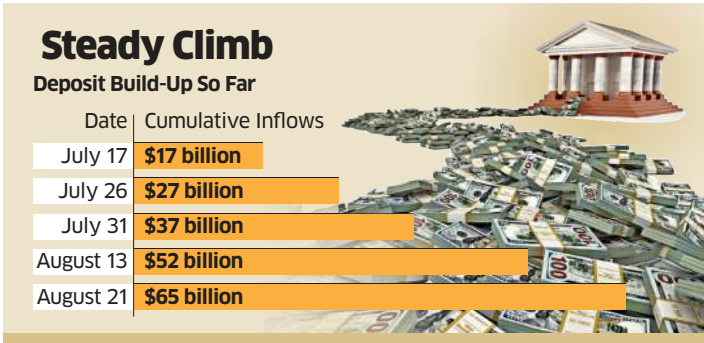
Mumbai: Strong momentum in foreign currency non-resident (bank), or FCNR (B), deposit inflows over the past week has prompted some analysts to raise their estimates for dollar inflows through the scheme.

Analysts said strong fundraising by banks and demand for the scheme among overseas investors mean inflows could exceed earlier estimates. Jefferies India Pvt Ltd said in a note on Monday that it now expects FCNR inflows to reach \$90 billion to \$100 billion by the time the scheme closes on August 31, compared with its earlier estimate of \$70 billion to \$80 billion. The new estimate is also higher than the \$80 billion that RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra estimated in an interview with a newspaper last week.

"Indian banks have mobilised US\$16bn over 8 days (13-21 Aug) through FCNR-B and other schemes to a total of \$73bn, exceeding our estimates. Given substantial debt issuance completed recently and in prospect, banks could cross our estimated range of raising \$70-80bn, landing at \$90-100bn by Aug 31," Jefferies analyst Prakhya Sharma said in the note.

Data released on Saturday showed FCNR (B) deposits accounted for a disproportionate share of the total dollar inflows, at \$65.39 billion out of \$72.80 billion. Banks added another \$13 billion through the FCNR (B) window over the past week, taking the total from \$52.30 billion as of August 13, the latest RBI update showed.

Higher inflows also mean the central bank will have to spend more to provide the swap facility, said Yes Bank chief economist Indrani Pan. "Also, since it is a bullet repayment, the dollars will have to be delivered in one go, which will have costs. One estimate we did showed that for \$65 billion of inflows, \$88 billion of dollars will have to be provided including interest costs," Pan said.



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ON ALERT Concentration risk sharpest in commercial vehicles, which have grown 20% annually to ₹7.4 lakh crore as of June-end, data shows

Multiple Vehicle Loans, Bigger Tickets Raise Risk for Lenders

Atmadip Ray

Kolkata: More vehicle buyers are taking multiple loans, while the average amount borrowed per customer is also rising, potentially increasing credit risks for lenders.

The rise in concentration risk is most pronounced in commercial vehicle finance, which has grown at a 20% compound annual rate to ₹7.4 lakh crore as of June end, data from Crif High Mark showed.

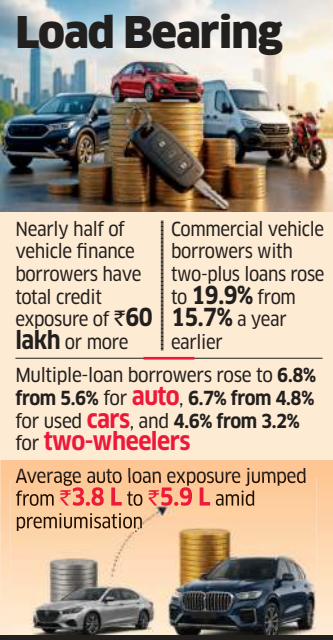
The share of commercial vehicle loan borrowers altogether having two or more loans rose to 19.9% from 15.7% a year earlier. Meanwhile, the average vehicle loan exposure per borrower for buying passenger taxies to heavy trucks increased to ₹7.8 lakh from ₹6.4 lakh.

"Exposure to multiple loans calls for intense monitoring by the lenders at the micro level as there can be spillover effects in case of defaults," Bank of Baroda chief economist Madan Sabnavis said.

"As they are small operators, care needs to be taken when disbursing loans which includes going through the credit history of the borrower as well as monitoring the same," he said.

Nearly half of the vehicle finance borrowers hold credit exposures of ₹60 lakh or more, reflecting strong and established credit relationships driven by high-ticket loans such as housing finance alongside vehicle finance. They also have unsecured loans, the Crif report showed.

The commercial vehicle loan segment carries the highest early bucket stress, according to the credit information company. "Within the borrower base, a growing micro segment of multi-loan borrowers is emerging, underscoring the need for deeper bureau checks to assess concentration risks," it noted in a report.



Auto loans, used to buy personal cars, saw the share of borrowers with two or more loan accounts rising to 6.8% at the end of the first quarter of FY27 from 5.6% seen a year back. Likewise, the ratio rose to 6.7% from 4.8% for used car loans and to 4.6% against 3.2% for two-wheeler loans.

The auto loan segment saw the sharpest rise in borrower level exposure with average loan rising to ₹5.9 lakh from ₹3.8 lakh as a reflection of rising premiumisation. "This is an interesting trend as individuals are taking more leverage," Sabnavis said. "In fact, overall leverage including vehicle, home, personal, credit card, etc has been going up, which is a pointer to consumerism."

The share of vehicle finance to the overall retail credit pie remains the same at 11.4% over a five-year horizon. Auto loans accounted for the largest share within the wheel segment at ₹9.9 lakh crore at the end of June, growing 17.6% year-on-year, while two-wheeler loans remained the largest borrower segment, expanding to 36 million borrowers from about 23 million over 12 months, underscoring their role as the mainstay entry-level credit.

SoftBank Sells Lenskart Shares worth ₹2,888 cr

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Japanese technology investor SoftBank has sold shares worth about ₹2,888 crore (\$300 million) in eyewear retailer Lenskart through a block deal on Monday.

SoftBank sold 45 million shares, or about 2.6% of Lenskart, at ₹641.75 apiece, exchange data showed. Its stake in the company will fall to around 7.3% from 9.86% at the end of the June quarter.

The latest stock sale takes SoftBank's returns from its investment in Lenskart to 5.7 times.

This is SoftBank's second large block sale in Lenskart since the six-month lock-in for pre-IPO investors expired in May. In June, it sold a 3.25% stake for ₹2,873 crore at ₹508.55 per share. It had earlier sold shares worth ₹1,026 crore through Lenskart's November 2025 IPO. In total, including public and private stake sales, SoftBank has realised around \$750 million from its investment in Lenskart.

Its residual 7.3% stake in the company is worth around \$850 million at current prices. The Masayoshi Son-led investor had invested \$280 million in total in Lenskart, first backing the company in 2019 when it was valued at \$1.5 billion.

Image Matters More Than Fines

►► From Page 1

FSSAI earlier warned celebrities in a social media post against endorsing foods with unverified or misleading claims, saying breaching guidelines would invite stringent penalties.

Experts, however, said brand ambassadors are more concerned about reputational risks than regulatory penalties.

"Naming and shaming, and viral content on social media, are starting to hurt celebrities. It's not so much about financial penalties, which may not be steep for celebrities since they charge multiple times that penalty," said Sandeep Goyal, managing director of ad agency Rediffusion, which works closely with several A-listers endorers across movies and cricket. "It's about the fear of stringent action and repercussions that did not ever happen earlier."

He believes the pushback indicates respect for the law and recognition that the regulator could enforce its writ, saying, "What's happening now is a good trigger and indicates provisions of law can't be looked through."

The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration, too, issued show-cause notices to actors Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff on August 16 for endorsing Vimal

Elaichi, alleging that the ads indirectly promote pan masala and tobacco-related products by the same name, which are banned in Maharashtra.

Executives representing celebrities, however, said while they have stepped up due diligence on contract fineprints, they can't be held responsible for every misstep by brands.

"The equation between a celebrity and brand is transactional. How can a celebrity be held responsible for, say, every single process in any given brand's factory?" said Afzar Zaidi, founder of talent management firm Exceed Group of Companies, which has represented well-known actors such as Hrithik Roshan and Saif Ali Khan. "While the decision to endorse any brand is an individual's and his or her prerogative, what is happening now is that there is undue pressure on the star."

FSSAI said it has issued 150 notices to food cos, in recent months over misleading ads, false claims & non-compliance with labelling regulations. The Nifty MidCap 150 and Nifty SmallCap 250 gained 1.6% and 1.1%, respectively, in July and have risen 1.2% and 2.8%, respectively, so far in August. Aggarwal said equity markets have remained range-bound amid multiple headwinds, including the

Y Combinator Gets ₹970 cr from Meesho Stake Sale

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Silicon Valley startup accelerator Y Combinator has sold shares worth nearly ₹970 crore in ecommerce firm Meesho through a block deal on Monday, days after cashing out ₹1,435 crore from stockbroking platform Groww.

Y Combinator sold a combined 4.85 crore Meesho shares at ₹200.01 apiece, exchange data showed. The sale represents just over 1% of the ecommerce company's equity.

The transaction adds to Y Combinator's returns from Meesho, which it first backed after the company joined the accelerator's 2016 batch. It had also sold 71.95 lakh shares in Meesho's December initial public offering for nearly ₹80 crore. For a tranche of Y Combinator's holding, Meesho's IPO documents disclosed an acquisition cost of ₹1.02 per share.

At Monday's sale price of ₹200.01, that translates to a gross return of about 196 times on those shares.

Comparable acquisition costs are not publicly available for all of Y Combinator's Meesho holdings, making it difficult to calculate an overall return on its investment.

Volatility Hit Transactions

►► From Page 1

Another public-sector major, Cochin Shipyard, raised nearly ₹1,705 crore in July. "The primary market does not necessarily require a sharply rising index; it requires liquidity, reasonable volatility and confidence in individual companies," said Munish Aggarwal, co-head, investment banking, Equirus Capital. Companies and shareholders had postponed transactions during extreme volatility in the immediate aftermath of the West Asian war.

They are now using the improved market window to raise growth capital, reduce debt, finance acquisitions, meet regulatory requirements, and provide exits to promoters and private-equity investors, experts said.

The surge in capital-market activity comes even as benchmark indices have remained range-bound. The Sensex and Nifty gained 2.1% and 2.2%, respectively, in July, but declined 0.5% and 0.7%, respectively, so far in August, as oil prices have hardened yet again.

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The impact on the rupee has also been limited, with the Indian currency broadly trading in the ₹95 to ₹96 per dollar range and showing no signs of a sharp rise.

"The impact on the rupee has been marginal because oil prices remain high. Unless oil comes down to \$75 to \$80 per barrel, the pressure on the rupee will continue. We are sticking with our estimate of rupee at ₹97 per dollar by the end of the fiscal year," Pan said.

The Indian currency closed at Rs 95.74 per dollar on Monday. Brent crude was trading at around \$93 per barrel on Monday.

Upasna Bhardwaj, chief economist at Kotak Mahindra Bank, said the bank had expected \$70 billion of inflows from FCNR (B) deposits but now expects \$75 billion to \$80 billion because of the momentum.

"Perhaps the RBI expected strong inflows and curtailed the timeline," she said, referring to the RBI advancing the deadline for banks to accept incentive-laden FCNR (B) deposits to August 31 by a month.

InCred Brings in Avendus Trio for UHNI Push

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: InCred hired three senior executives who helped rival Avendus build its wealth management business to lead a new platform focused on ultra-high-net-worth individuals, as financial firms compete for a growing pool of wealthy Indian clients.

Alok Agrawal, Harmeet Sahney and Zarkis Gotla joined InCred as cofounders of InCred Black, a new business targeting UHNIs, entrepreneurs and business families, the company said Monday. The trio spent more than 15 years building the wealth business at Avendus and advised some of the most prominent UHNI clients. Agrawal, Sahney and Gotla will help shape InCred Black, deepen client relationships and expand the team as the business scales, it said.

The move comes as the country's pool of wealthy individuals expands and family offices increasingly seek access to private markets, alternative investments and global assets. According to InCred, its wealth franchise has crossed ₹1 lakh crore in assets under management and serves a large UHNI client base.

InCred Black will offer personalised wealth management and access to asset allocation, alternative investments, public and private markets, credit, liquidity solutions and global investing, leveraging capabilities across InCred Capital and the wider InCred group, it said.

Tech Picks

AJIT MISHRA, SVP- Research

Religare Broking

CDSL

Rebound after forming a base around the moving averages ribbon. Recovery to strengthen further.

LAST CLOSE ► ₹1,385.10 STOP LOSS ► ₹1,325

BUY

TARGET ₹1,480

HINDALCO

Noticeable outperformance by the metal pack; uptrend set to resume after a marginal pause.

LAST CLOSE ► ₹1,058.50 STOP LOSS ► ₹1,015

BUY

TARGET ₹1,150

SIEMENS

Fresh breakout after a breather. Expect to retest the record high soon.

LAST CLOSE ► ₹4,114 STOP LOSS ► ₹3,890

BUY

TARGET ₹4,480

BANKBARODA

Completed the formation of shorting pivot. Weakness in PSU banking pack added negative.

LAST CLOSE ► ₹241.50 STOP LOSS ► ₹246

SELL

TARGET ₹232

GAS COMPRESSION PROJECT PEGGED AT OVER ₹15K CR

L&T Wins Ultra-Mega Contract in West Asia

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Larsen & Toubro (L&T) said Monday it has signed an ultra-mega contract to implement a gas compression project for a major client in the Gulf, expanding its presence in large-scale hydrocarbon infrastructure.

L&T classifies orders above ₹15,000 crore as ultra-mega. The engineering and construction conglomerate, however, didn't disclose the value of the contract.

The contract has been awarded to L&T Energy Hydrocarbon Onshore (LTEH Onshore), a subsidiary of L&T. The company will undertake engineering, procurement and construction (EPC) of gas compression plants for new onshore installations designed to process sour gas.

The project includes gas inlet facilities, gas compression systems, condensate and produced-water handling systems, propane refrigeration systems and associated utilities. The facilities will be developed as per the client's standards, codes and project requirements.

L&T's power transmission and distribution business will also execute two 230-kV extra-high-

voltage substations to meet the power requirements of the gas compression plants.

"The contract marks the start of a strategically important project that will add significant gas compression capacity and utility infrastructure," said E S Sathyanarayanan, senior vice president and head of L&T Energy Hydrocarbon Onshore.

He said the project would draw on L&T's experience in executing large and complex hydrocarbon facilities and strengthen its capability to deliver integrated solutions for challenging sour-gas applications. LTEH Onshore provides turnkey solutions across the value chain, from upstream, midstream and downstream hydrocarbon sectors. Its portfolio includes refinery expansions, petrochemical complexes, gas processing plants, fertiliser plants, LNG terminals and cross-country pipelines.

Shares of L&T closed nearly unchanged at ₹4,085.3 apiece on the BSE.

The contract has been awarded to L&T subsidiary L&T Energy Hydrocarbon Onshore; value remains undisclosed

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Suzlon Plans 1,325 MW Wind Projects in Andhra

Shilpa Ranipeta

Hyderabad: Suzlon Group is set to develop 1,325 MW of new wind energy projects in Andhra Pradesh's Rayadurg constituency in Anantapur district, involving an investment of around ₹10,000 crore, as the wind energy major expands its renewable energy footprint in the state.

The projects are expected to create around 4,000 direct and indirect jobs, a statement said. Andhra Pradesh education, IT and electronics minister Nara Lokesh will inaugurate Suzlon's new S144 wind blades at Huliker village in Kanekallu mandal on Tuesday.

Suzlon, which has more than

1,700 MW of installed wind energy capacity in Andhra Pradesh, is targeting an additional 5 GW of renewable energy projects in the state by 2030.

The company began operations in Andhra Pradesh in 2004 and has established a significant manufacturing and project presence in Anantapur district, including a rotor blade manufacturing facility at Ippuru in Kuderu mandal.

Suzlon said it has invested about ₹12,000 crore in Andhra Pradesh so far. Its Anantapur blade manufacturing facility accounts for around 40% of the company's blade production, with an annual production capacity equivalent to 1,260 MW.

Centre of Excellence to be Set Up

►► From Page 1

The software company brings scale to MHP's capabilities in product engineering, manufacturing, operations and customer experience.

It also has expertise in the areas of digital consulting, digital transformation advisory, S/4HANA transformation, and software-defined vehicles, Krithivasan added. S/4HANA refers to the modernisation of enterprise resource planning systems.

Porsche is a new client for TCS and the deal will be a fresh one for the company. The acquisition will anchor a long-term AI transformation partnership between TCS and Porsche, the company said. As part of the transaction, TCS will also set up a centre of excellence (CoE) for Porsche to help with its future growth.

This marks the IT company's third significant acquisition within the year. Following the ₹72.8 million purchase of digital marketing services business ListEngage in October last year, the IT services giant paid \$700 million for Florida-based Salesforce consulting and AI solutions company Coastal Cloud in December.

The acquisition is expected to be concluded in the next three-four months, subject to regulatory approvals from the European Commission and others.

Ludwigsburg, Germany-headquartered MHP specialises in automotive and industrial consulting, digital transformation,

artificial intelligence, SAP transformation, manufacturing digitalisation, connected mobility and software-defined mobility. It employs around 4,500 people and reported turnover of ₹742 million in calendar 2025.

The five-year engagement is expected to be margin-dilutive to the tune of 50-60 basis points for TCS in the next four to six quarters, Krithivasan said.

"In the short term it will be dilutive, but then we have to exercise all the other levers that we have at our disposal to improve the margin," he said. "Even in this particular deal, currently MHP does not have any offshore component, which we continue to introduce more of, so the margin of the entity will keep going up."

The deal gives TCS a deeper position within the Porsche technology landscape at a time when AI spending is beginning to scale, said Gaurav Parab, principal analyst at NelsonHall.

"Being embedded in Porsche's applications, data and engineering environment should put TCS in a good position to pick up future AI, data and transformation work," he said. "While the deal will dilute margins initially, TCS should have room to improve the economics over time through global delivery, automation and, importantly, by bringing more AI-led and higher-value services into these relationships."

The Indian company's largest-ever contract was with British insurance giant Aviva, a 15-year agreement valued at \$2.5 billion, signed in 2024.



Meesho's IPO documents disclosed an acquisition cost of ₹1.02 per share.



prolonged West Asia conflict, higher crude and logistics costs, and concerns over the sustainability of IT earnings in the AI era. Domestic institutional and retail flows have provided a counterbalance to uneven overseas purchases, undergirding benchmarks and providing companies with the necessary confidence to tap the capital markets.

Retain contributions through systematic investment plans (SIP) stood at approximately ₹31,961 crore in July, while active equity funds received nearly ₹24,700 crore, providing domestic institutions with significant capital to deploy. The broader 2026 numbers underline the strength of the fundraising cycle.



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CERC Lets Delayed RE Developers to Retain Grid Access for Compensation

PTI

New Delhi: Renewable energy developers facing implementation delays will be able to retain allocated access to the transmission grid for an extended period by paying compensation, according to the latest order by regulator CERC.

The Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC) has introduced a graded compensation mechanism, replacing the earlier regime under which grid connectivity or transmission links granted to RE developers were revoked if projects failed to meet milestones at various stages within the stipulated timeframe.

The order provides for the levy of compensation for additional time to achieve milestones under the Connectivity and General Network Access to the Inter-State Transmission System Regulations, 2022.

Noting that several entities are seeking extra time to implement RE projects and retain grid connectivity, the CERC, in its order, said a number of such cases had been disposed of by the commission by granting additional time on payment of compensation.

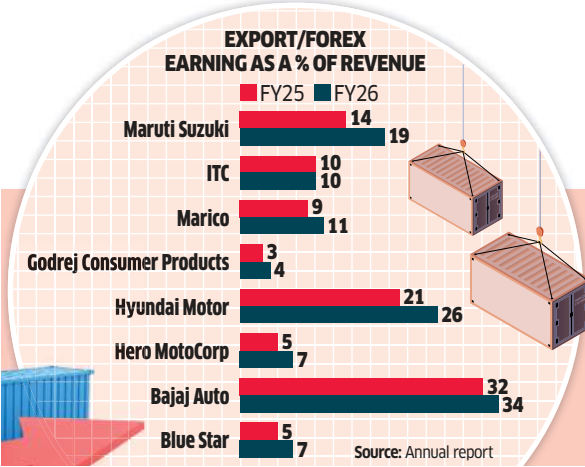
The CERC said there was an immediate requirement to handle such cases uniformly, where entities had made progress towards project implementation and were seeking additional time to meet the milestones under the GNA Regulations.

The regulator also observed that such entities were holding on to connectivity, a scarce resource. Therefore, additional time should be allowed, with payment of compensation, irrespective of the reasons for the delay, in a graded manner to ensure the earliest compliance with the milestones.

Under the new mechanism, the connectivity milestones include submission of documents for 50% of the land required for the connectivity sought, achieving financial closure and project commissioning.

For seeking additional time to submit land documents, the RE developer must have documents for a minimum of 20% of the land required and must submit the application at least 15 working days before the original compliance deadline expires.

Consumer Companies' Forex Earnings Shine Amid Global Struggles



Writankar Mukherjee

Kolkata: Leading consumer-facing manufacturers of daily essentials and household products, automobiles, consumer electronics and liquor stepped up exports in FY26, boosting foreign exchange earnings and collectively turning net forex positive despite sizeable import bills, showed an ET study of 20 large publicly traded companies.

The combined export forex earnings of these companies grew 29% last fiscal year, the fastest pace in four years. In FY22, forex earnings had grown 55%, but on a lower FY21 base when operations were severely disrupted by the pandemic.

The growth came in a year when companies faced headwinds from US tariffs and a sharply weaker rupee, making imports more expensive.

They nevertheless managed to navigate the pressures by increasing localisation.

The combined forex earnings from exports of companies including ITC, Maruti Suzuki, Hyundai Motor India, LG Electronics, Hero MotoCorp, Dabur, Asian Paints, Pidilite Industries, Tata Consumer Products, Voltas and United Spirits exceeded ₹1,08,269 crore in FY26, the study showed. Their combined forex outgo on imports of raw materials, components, spare parts, and capital goods stood at ₹1,04,361 crore, growing 17%.

The data, sourced from annual reports and registrar of companies statutory filings, showed Maruti Suzuki, Marico, Godrej Consumer Products, Hyundai, Hero MotoCorp, Bajaj Auto and Blue Star increased contribution of exports to total revenue by 1.5 percentage points in FY26. "At a time when there are headwinds from rupee depreciation and rising input costs, we will continue to expand our exports by adding new geographies and product categories, which will also benefit margins," said Atul Khanna, chief accounting officer at LG Electronics India. "Localisation will also go up by 1.2 percentage points every year."

ITC said, in its latest annual report, that it considers foreign exchange earnings a priority, with all its businesses mandated to engage with overseas markets to test and demonstrate international competitiveness and pursue profitable growth opportunities.

Liquor maker Radico Khaitan's managing director Abhishek Khaitan said the company currently exports to more than 100 countries, accounting for 5-6% of volumes but a higher share by value.

PPPAC Expects ₹8,622 crore Capex for Privatising 11 Airports

Concessions to span 50 years across five bundles; bidder cap proposed to curb concentration

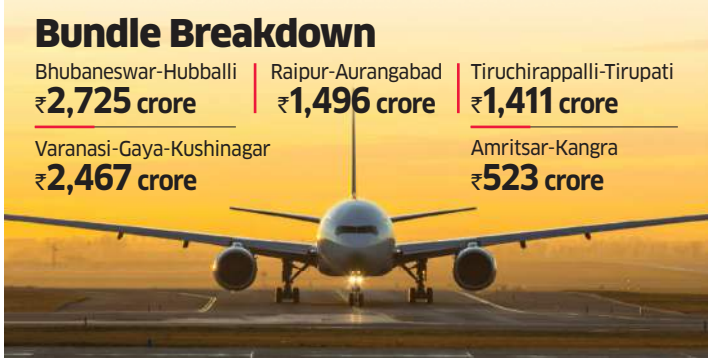
Forum Gandhi

Mumbai: India expects private operators to invest approximately ₹8,622 crore in 11 airports that the government plans to award under 50-year concessions, with the Bhubaneswar-Hubbali bundle requiring the highest investment.

The Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC) gave in-principle approval to the proposal at its August 4 meeting, according to minutes reviewed by ET. The airports will be offered in five bundles, with each bundle awarded to a single concessionaire.

The Bhubaneswar-Hubbali bundle has the highest estimated investment requirement at ₹2,725 crore, followed by Varanasi-Gaya-Kushinagar at ₹2,467 crore. Raipur-Aurangabad requires ₹1,496 crore, Tiruchirappalli-Tirupati ₹1,411 crore and Amritsar-Kangra ₹523 crore.

The investment will cover capital expenditure by concessionaires, including spending already sanctioned by the Airports Authority of India (AAI) and additional expenditure required to expand capacity.



Sanctioned capital expenditure will have to be completed within three years of the commercial operations date. Further expansion will be linked to traffic and capacity thresholds under Airports Economic Regulatory Authority norms, according to the minutes. The government is also looking to limit concentration by capping the number of airport bundles that a single bidder can win.

"The number of airport bundles that may be awarded to a single bidder would be capped," the minutes said, citing risks from market concentration and potential over-leveraging. The modalities of the cap are still being worked out.

India Post Rolls Out 2 Apps for Citizens, Staff

Our Bureau

New Delhi: In a modernisation drive to improve rural reach, India Post on Monday launched two cloud-based apps, customer-facing Dak Sewa and employee-only Dak Mitra, to offer postal services digitally. This is the first time citizens can book parcels, check their savings and access insurance services under a single interface without visiting a post office.

Communications minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said India Post, one of the country's oldest institutions, is being modernised to meet the needs of the 21st century.

Minister of state for communications Chandra Sekhar Pemasani said that over the past few decades, India Post had gradually lost relevance among younger, digital-native Indians who turned to private digital platforms for logistics, insurance and financial services.

The two apps, Dak Mitra for India Post employees and Dak Sewa for citizens, combine postal, banking and insurance services on a single interface.

The Dak Mitra app has been operational since May 2025 across 1.4 lakh branch post offices and has facilitated 2.45 crore domestic Speed Post and parcel bookings, along with the delivery of 15.09 crore postal articles.

The Dak Sewa app, meanwhile, was piloted in June 2025 and has recorded 10 lakh downloads and 14 renovated post offices now operational.

Scindia said India Post's revenue increased 16% YoY to ₹15,296 crore in FY26 and crossed the ₹4,000 crore mark in the first quarter of FY27, registering 22% YoY growth.

ADVT

THE ECONOMIC TIMES

CAMPUS SPOTLIGHT

KJU Organizes Farmers Market at Campus

Kristu Jayanti (Deemed to be University), Airport Road Campus, organised its first campus farmers' market under the Kristu Jayanti Sarva Vikas Initiative, aligned with the Government of India's One District One Product (ODOP) scheme. The event brought together farmers, student entrepreneurs and staff to promote local products, sustainability and engagement. The market was inaugurated by Smt. Roopa VM, Assistant Director of Agriculture, Bangalore North Taluk along with Fr Dr Lijo P Thomas, Pro VC of KJU, Dr Edward Aloysius, Registrar of KJU and other University officials. In his presidential address, Fr Thomas expressed KJU's readiness to support agribusiness-focused student-driven startups, which can be incubated and accelerated through the Kristu Jayanti Ideation, Incubation and Innovation Centre (KJIIC).

UPI@10: FROM DIGITAL PAYMENTS TO DIGITAL EMPOWERMENT

Ten years ago, India embarked on an ambitious journey to make digital payments instantaneous, interoperable and accessible. The launch of the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) in 2016 marked a decisive moment in that journey. Today, UPI is much more than a payment mechanism. It has become part of the everyday fabric of India's economy. From a street vendor accepting a QR payment to a family transferring money across cities, digital payments have brought unprecedented convenience and participation into the financial system.

The scale of this transformation is remarkable. From just 373 transactions in its first month of launch, UPI today processes around 83 crore transactions every day. In FY2025-26, it handled more than 24,000 crore transactions worth over ₹300 lakh crore, with more than 55 crore Indians using UPI. India now accounts for nearly half of global real-time payment transactions. India did not merely digitise payments; India democratised them.

Union Bank of India has been privileged to be part of this journey from its beginning. We were among the 21 pilot banks that participated in the launch of UPI in 2016. Today, Union Bank of India ranks 4th among the 741 UPI-enabled Banks. As of July 2026, Union Bank of India accounted for around 6% of India's UPI transaction volume, processing an average of over 4.5 crore transactions daily. In FY2025-26, Union Bank of India processed around 1385 crore UPI transactions worth ₹17.4 lakh crore. Union Bank of India's contribution to UPI ecosystem extends beyond scale. The Bank has deployed nearly three lakh PM SVANidhi QR codes, helping street vendors and micro-merchants participate in the digital economy, while embracing innovations such as UPI Lite, RuPay Credit Card on UPI, UPI Circle, UPI Global and Credit Line on UPI.

UPI's journey is also becoming a Global story. Cross-border UPI can make international payments and remittances simpler, efficient and cost-effective while wider international acceptance can complement the gradual internationalisation of the Indian Rupee. The foundations for this transformation were laid through the convergence of Jan Dhan, Aadhaar and mobile connectivity - the JAM Trinity. Jan Dhan expanded access to formal banking, Aadhaar provided a trusted digital identity, and mobile connectivity created an accessible channel. UPI brought these elements together into an interoperable financial ecosystem.



By Shri Asheesh Pandey
Managing Director & CEO,
Union Bank of India

The result was a fundamental change in the meaning of a bank account. It became not merely a place to save money, receive a government benefit or withdraw cash, but a gateway to participate in the formal economy - anytime and anywhere. The next phase is about moving from digital access to digital empowerment. Display of a QR code outside a rural shop represents Digital Access and the shopkeeper who transacts confidently and knows how to protect against fraud represents Empowerment.

Technology alone cannot deliver inclusion; Trust, Awareness and Human support remain equally important. This is why Branches and the Smartphones are complementary models of banking. Digital platforms provide speed and convenience, while branches and banking personnel provide the human connection that converts access into confidence.

At Union Bank of India, Union Digi-Gaon takes digital awareness and capacity-building directly to villages. Technology matters most when it simplifies lives. In Odisha, Union Bank of India's participation in the Subhadra Yojana subsidy-disbursement initiative using Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) demonstrates how sophisticated technology can deliver a simple outcome - ensuring that beneficiary receives entitlement securely, seamlessly and on time. In addition,

UPI ecosystem has been integrated with CBDC system such that digital rupee can flow seamlessly between these platforms. CBDC's interoperability with any UPI QR code has propelled the reach of digital rupee ensuring the rise of new-age payment system.

Digital empowerment cannot end with the ability to make payments. It must enable people and businesses to use their growing digital footprint to access wider financial opportunities. This is where the next phase of India's digital financial journey begins.

From Payments to Economic Opportunity The next frontier lies beyond payments. While UPI reduced friction in moving money, the Unified Lending Interface (ULI) has the potential to reduce friction in accessing credit. Combined with Consent-based data sharing and Artificial Intelligence, it can help create richer financial footprints for individuals and businesses. This is particularly significant for MSMEs, farmers and small entrepreneurs. The journey from UPI to ULI is therefore not simply the evolution of technology. It is the evolution of financial inclusion from access to opportunity.

The first decade of UPI connected India. The next decade will also be shaped by Artificial Intelligence to empower India - connecting payments with Credit, Data with consent, Intelligence with responsibility and Technology with trust.

AI and Automation can strengthen credit assessment, improve risk management, enhance customer service and reduce operational friction for Banks. At Union Bank of India, these technologies are being deployed to improve efficiency and allow branches to focus more on customer service.

With success of UPI, India demonstrated that it could build digital infrastructure at population scale. The opportunity before us now is to use that infrastructure to expand economic opportunity, strengthen financial resilience and build a more inclusive and prosperous Bharat. From banking the unbanked, to enabling digital participation, to empowering citizens and businesses - the journey has only just begun.

Disclaimer: An initiative of Union Bank of India. BCCL does not endorse and is not responsible for the accuracy or completeness of the information contained herein. Readers should seek appropriate professional advice before taking any decision.

CapitaLand Converting SGD Debt to Onshores

New Delhi: Singapore-based CapitaLand India Trust (CLINT) is in the process of converting outstanding debt held in Singapore dollars to rupees since INR has depreciated quite a lot in the past 12-18 months, a senior executive said. As of June 2026, CLINT, which manages 22 millions square feet spread across Bengaluru, Chennai, Hyderabad, Pune and Mumbai, had approximately \$81.7 billion (roughly ₹8,820 crore) of borrowings. As of June, CLINT's

assets under management stood at \$83.5 billion. About 53% of the debt is already aligned to INR, comprising 29% of onshore INR debt and a further 24% that is economically hedged into INR via structures in Singapore. "Our debt onshoring programme is part of a broader capital management strategy to progressively align our funding structure with the markets in which we operate..." said Gauri Shankar Nagabhushanam, CEO, CapitaLand India Trust. —Faizan Haidar

Hawkins Cookers Limited

Registered Office: Maker Tower F 101, Cuffe Parade, Mumbai 400005. CIN: L28997MH1959PLC011304 Tel: 022-2218 6607 E-mail: ho@hawkinscookers.com Website: www.hawkinscookers.com

NOTICE OF POSTAL BALLOT BY REMOTE E-VOTING ONLY

1. Notice is hereby given that pursuant to Sections 108 and 110 of the Companies Act, 2013, read with Rules 20 and 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, Regulation 44 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, other applicable laws, rules and regulations and the relevant MCA and SEBI Circulars' guidelines, the approval of the Members is sought for the ratification of the remuneration payable to the Cost Auditor appointed by the Board of Directors for the Financial Year 2026-27, by an Ordinary Resolution through the remote e-voting ("e-voting") process.

2. As required, the Postal Ballot Notice has been emailed on August 24, 2026, to those Members of the Company as on the cut-off date of August 19, 2026, who have registered their email id with their Depository Participant (DP) and the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, MUFG Intime India Pvt. Ltd. (RTA), informing them about e-voting on the proposed Ordinary Resolution. The same is also available at www.hawkinscookers.com, www.evoting.nsdl.com and www.bseindia.com.

3. As per the applicable MCA Circulars, Members can exercise their vote on the resolution proposed to be considered for postal ballot through the e-voting services provided by NSDL at https://www.evoting.nsdl.com. The e-voting period commences at 9:00 am on Tuesday, August 25, 2026, and ends at 5:00 pm on Wednesday, September 23, 2026, after which e-voting shall not be allowed. Names recorded in the Register of Members or in the Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the cut-off date of August 19, 2026, shall only be entitled to avail the said facility of e-voting. Any person who is not a member of the Company as on the said cut-off date shall treat the Postal Ballot Notice for information purpose only.

4. Members with demat shares are requested to register their email addresses with their DP and those with physical holdings with the RTA. As mandated by SEBI, Members holding physical shares must ensure their KYC details are duly registered and/or updated with the RTA. Members holding demat shares must do so with their DPs. In case of any query or assistance, Members may send an email to the Company at cosec@hawkinscookers.com.

5. Any query or grievance on remote e-voting may be raised to Mr. Amit Vishal, Vice President, NSDL, 3rd Floor, Naman Chamber, Plot C-32, G Block, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra, Mumbai-400051; or to evoting@nsdl.com; Or, by calling: 022-4886 7000.

For Hawkins Cookers Limited
Brahmananda Pani,
Company Secretary

Mumbai
August 24, 2026

TIMES ascent

Catapult your career

WANTED : HEAD OF MARKETING

A leading industrial group based in Central India seeks a dynamic, results-driven Marketing Head. The position is based in a metro city : Delhi, Mumbai or Bangalore. The primary responsibility is to lead and manage the marketing of Protein extracted from Rice.

- **Qualification :** Master's degree in Marketing, Business, or related field.
- **Experience :** Minimum [5-8] years of Proven Experience in a leadership role.
- **Skills :** Excellent Leadership, Communication and Strategic Planning Skills.

What We Offer :

- Competitive salary package matching industry standards.
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Interested candidates should email their updated resume and cover letter to E-mail : protein.project@kediagroup.com

SBI State Bank of India

Central Recruitment & Promotion Department
Corporate Centre, Mumbai
Phone: 022-22820427

RECRUITMENT OF JUNIOR ASSOCIATES (CUSTOMER SUPPORT & SALES) IN CLERICAL CADRE IN STATE BANK OF INDIA (SBI)

Applications are invited from eligible Indian citizens for appointment as Junior Associates (Customer Support & Sales) in State Bank of India on regular basis.

NUMBER OF VACANCIES:
REGULAR: 7680 + BACKLOG: 287

Eligibility criteria (age, qualification, etc.), requisite fees and other details, along with the link for online submission of applications and online payment of fee, are available on Bank's website https://sbi.bank.in/web/careers/current-openings under Advertisement no. CRPD/CR/2026-27/17. Candidates are advised to go through the detailed advertisement and ensure their eligibility and other details before applying and remitting fees.

• **DATE FOR FILING ONLINE APPLICATION & PAYMENT OF FEES:** 11.08.2026 TO 31.08.2026.

For any query, please write to us through link "CONTACT US" → "Post Your Query" which is available on Bank's website https://sbi.bank.in/web/careers/current-openings

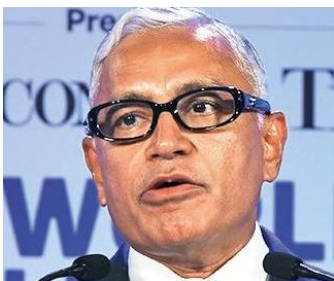
Place: Mumbai
Date: 11.08.2026
General Manager (RP&PM)

TIMES ascent global

Catapult your career

ICVL International Coal Ventures Private Limited

ICVL, a JV of Indian PSU's setup for acquisition of coal assets overseas and owning and operating coking coal mine / assets in Mozambique, invites applications for the post of MD & CEO at ICVL Mozambique for a period of 2 years, extendable by 1 year, at a consolidated salary of US\$ 13,000 per month. For eligibility criteria and other T&C's visit our website https://icvl.in. Last date for submission of online applications is 14th Sep 2026. Addendum / corrigendum shall be notified on our website only.

SIVAKUMAR SUNDARAM
 CEO, THE TIMES OF INDIA


India Needs Insulation, Not Isolation

Team ET

India does not need protection from a world increasingly defined by geopolitical uncertainty and unpredictable shocks, but the ability to absorb these without closing itself off, Sivakumar Sundaram, CEO, The Times of India, said Friday at the World Leaders Forum. "What India needs is not shelter from the storm, it is insulation," Sundaram said in his welcome address. He drew a distinction between insulation and isolation, saying the former meant "staying open to the world without catching every draught going through it."

Sundaram argued that reforms and institutional changes over the past decade should be viewed through this lens. Individually, measures such as the GST, insolvency reforms and the digital payments infrastructure may not always make for compelling headlines, but collectively they have strengthened India's ability to withstand shocks. "None of these are headlines. Individually, they are certainly boring," he said, before adding that such mechanisms become important when "the road gets bumpy." And, he said, "the road is getting bumpy" as the world "is running on impulses and on reaction to impulses and increasingly on reactions to reactions."

He pointed to India's economic rise, its position as fourth largest and fastest-growing major economy and the conclusion of a free trade pact with the EU as markers of a country that is simultaneously opening up and building resilience.

BORIS JOHNSON FORMER BRITISH PRIME MINISTER

India, US, UK Must Work Together to Find a Way Out of W Asia Crisis

Johnson regrets that US did not consult UK on Iran war; insists Putin was fated to lose the war in Ukraine


Team ET

From whipping out a comb to tame his unruly mane, former British Prime Minister Boris Johnson transitioned to an in-depth discussion on messy geopolitics at The Economic Times World Leaders Forum. He praised India effusively, expressed deep dissatisfaction over the US failing to consult the UK on the Iran war and insisted that Vladimir Putin was fated to lose the war in Ukraine. Johnson said India is going through a very good period under very strong and stable leadership. "The Indian story today is a really wonderful story," he said, predicting an "incredible future" for India because it is a democracy and a free country.

He also hailed the India-UK free-trade agreement, negotiations for which began when he was the PM. "The free trade deal that I started... it was good, we've done a lot, but there's a lot more to do," Johnson told ET's Sruthijith KK in a fireside chat, richly peppered with his characteristic straight shooting and humour that triggered ro-



unds of laughter among a keenly attentive audience.

He said India, the US and the UK should work together to find a way out of the Iran crisis.

US-IRAN WAR & ROLE OF UK

Johnson regretted that the US did not consult the UK on the Iran war. "And I honestly think that was a mistake.... if I'd been the prime minister when that thing kicked off, it would not have happened. Because, if you remember, this is the third Gulf War. The first two Gulf wars, the US and the UK were absolutely shoulder to shoulder. There was even a joint cabinet, with Margaret Thatcher and George HW Bush, and Tony Blair and the younger Bush, that absolutely coordinated their efforts."

He termed US President Donald Trump a "deeply consultative type of person". "I've been lying comatose in hotels in Miami when he rang me up and asked my opinion

TRADE WINDS

The free trade deal (with India) that I started... it was good, we've done a lot, but there's a lot more to do

on something... I'm sure that (India) Prime Minister (Narendra) Modi knows this too. He loves to hear from his friends and to get advice. So, I think that we should have done more (consultations). I really, really regret it." Johnson was of the opinion that the UK could have played a stronger role in preventing the US from walking into what he described as an "obvious, obvious trap" in its war with Iran. "Someone should have interrogated the US, if not President Trump, his planners, the Pentagon — what is the objective of this war," he said. Britain, as one of the US' closest allies, should have sought clarity on Washington's strategy and its

plans in the event of Iran closing the Strait of Hormuz. "And we are your No.1 ally, right? We're your feeder circadians. We're your loyal hedge person," Johnson said. Johnson called for alternative logistical arrangements, including pipelines and other routes that could reduce dependence on the Strait of Hormuz.

Negotiations with Iran are tough, Johnson said. "Once they think they've got you, once they've got something over you, once they've got something on you, you're stuck, and they will continue to weaponise whatever advantage they have. I wish I could say I was optimistic about negotiations."

INDIA-UK FTA

Johnson said he was thrilled that the FTA had happened. "It is a great deal... if I have achieved nothing else in my life, I have cut the tariffs. I have persuaded, helped to persuade, the brilliant, doughty, remorseless Indian negotiators to cut the tariffs with exorbitant 150% tariffs on Scotch whisky to 75%, and going down, and going down further, to 40% in the next few years." He credited India for playing a key role in Britain's Covid-19 vaccination drive, saying he personally received the Indian version of the AstraZeneca vaccine during the pandemic.

US HEGEMONY VS CHINA

The former UK PM described the US as the world's hegemonic power and said he would prefer Washington to retain that role over China. "Given where we are, I'd rather have America than China. Now, given where we are, people who love America and want to help America have got to think what we can do to get the strait open, help America out of the cul-de-sac. That's what we've got to do. And I think probably that goes for India too," he said. "I appreciate that it's very difficult right now for India, it's difficult for the whole world, it's a very, very tough position to be in. But we've got to find a deal with Iran, difficult though that will be, and brutal negotiators though they are, we've got to do that."

UK POLITICS

On UK PM Andy Burnham, Johnson said, "He's doing a lot of things that I did, actually like the £2 bus pass."

Referring to PM Modi's speech at the ET World Leaders Forum Friday, Johnson said it was brilliant because he talked about real issues that help people.

WLF DIARIES

Trouble in the Air, Literally

Guests flying in from London, including an advertising ace

and a Wall Street wonder woman, found their journey taking an unexpected turn at 30,000 feet. Just as their flight approached Indian airspace, an engine snag prompted a U-turn to West Asia, where repairs were apparently considered wiser than an intervention after touchdown in Delhi. The engine maker—a storied British name recently in the Indian headlines—thus added an unscheduled twist to the journey. Some flights, it seems, arrive with more baggage than passengers.

Silicon Valley Wedding, India Calling?

SF bros may be negotiating billion-dollar

cheques in Silicon Valley, but back home, the conversation shifts to wedding couture and exotic venues. Two Indian-origin startup stars were overheard comparing notes on potential wedding venues in Udaipur and Bhuaneswar. And turns out one bride-to-be has zeroed in on designers Tarun Tahiliani and Arpita Mehta.

THE INDIA-UAE GROWTH CORRIDOR INVESTING IN THE NEXT DECADE

\$25 b in 10 yrs, Room for More Investments

Need of the hour: Further improvement in ease of doing business and strengthening infrastructure



Abdulla Ziad Galadari of Galadari Advocates, KAAF Investments' Nandi Vardhan Mehta, Ekta Tolani of KBW Ventures, Nader Albastaki of Dubai Future District Fund and ADNOC Drilling's Youssef Salem

Team ET

The India-UAE growth corridor provides tremendous opportunities between the two countries for collaborating on trade, investments and talent, said industry executives and experts from UAE, while flagging the lack of a timebound legal framework for resolving disputes in India and inadequate infrastructure for supporting the ecosystem as key impediments to attracting more foreign direct investments (FDI).

The panel discussion on "The India-UAE Growth Corridor: Investing in the Next Decade" was moderated by ET's Deepshikha Sikarwar. "This corridor is an alleviation of what we had a century or several centuries ago," said Abdulla Ziad Galadari, senior partner at Galadari Advocates. "India, with its digital economy and demographics, partnering up with UAE, with its capital, experience in logistics and glo-

bal connectivity, creates a unique offering and experience," he said, adding whatever has been witnessed so far is just the beginning and that there is much more to follow.

While India received investments exceeding \$25 billion from the UAE in the past decade, experts said the country has the appetite for more but stressed on the need to further improve its ease of doing business and strengthen infrastructure for attracting more private investments from UAE to commensurate with the growth in trade between the two countries.

"If you look at ease of business, or ease of exit, or flexibility on the liquidity, or the legal reforms and infrastructure, India's performance is not as solid as the US, and hence, multi billions are going out from the UAE or the region to mostly the US," said Ekta Tolani, chief investment officer, KBW Ventures.

She said there is enough trust between the two nations, but the bilate-

SUPER ATTRACTIVE

India's 1 b urban population, its rapid foray into AI & transformation in the energy mix makes it super attractive

ral investment treaty (BIT) really needs to resolve the issues around family-to-family dialogue and come up with a legal framework to bring about a change in the private investment perspective. "We should not be happy about the \$25 billion into India in the last 10-12 years," said Nandi Vardhan Mehta, chief financial officer at KAAF Investments, suggesting the need to enhance capital movement between the private families in the two countries. "We have more money over there and more appetite here in India."

Mehta said the real growth in job creation and capacity will happen through private sector investment for which India needs to build co-investing vehicles such as the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund or a credible sovereign institution as an anchor to let families around the world co-invest.

Experts highlighted that there is greater exchange of talent and technology between the two countries, thanks to the corridor. Nader Albastaki, managing director at Dubai Future District Fund said while enhancing trade was the whole purpose of the bilateral movement, of late, there is also movement of talent from India to the UAE. "We've seen over 4,000 Indian businesses setting up shops and doing business in the UAE," said Albastaki. "We're seeing fund managers raising capital to create and double down on this bridge between India and the UAE, and we're seeing innovation," he said.

Identifying energy as the key driver of attracting private investment from the UAE, experts said India's rising urban population, the AI revolution in the country, and its commitment towards green energy makes it a super attractive destination for investments. "India's estimated one billion urban population, its rapid foray into AI revolution and massive transformation in the energy mix makes it super, super, attractive," said Youssef Salem, chief financial officer at ADNOC Drilling, adding that India's deepest talent pool will drive growth in both India and Abu Dhabi.

UNIQUE PARTNERSHIP

India, with its digital economy, partnering with UAE, with its experience in global connectivity, creates a unique offering and experience

DAVID BACH PRESIDENT, IMD

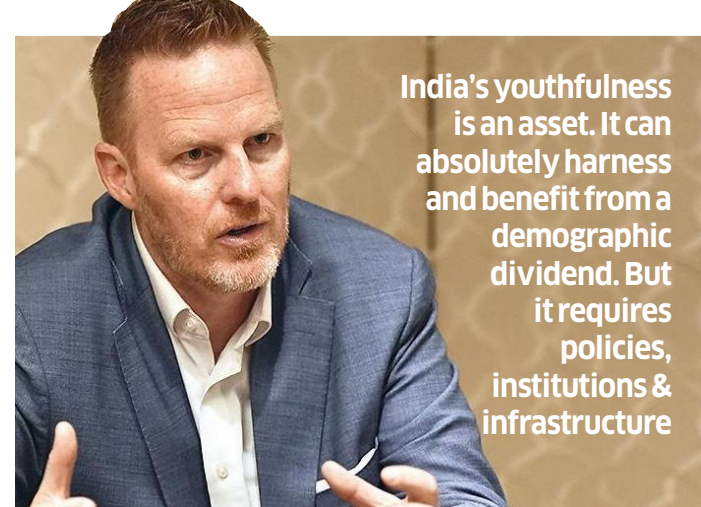
Tech Doesn't Disrupt in its Own Right, it Disrupts when it's Widely Deployed

AI promises incredible opportunities for businesses, from creating new value for customers and driving innovation to boosting productivity. At the same time, companies face substantial investment needs, the challenge of upskilling employees and questions around data and governance. This is a major transformation for each enterprise, and, like any transformation project, it requires a fairly clear vision of what you are trying to accomplish, David Bach, president and Nestlé professor of strategy and political economy at IMD Business School, told **Saumya Bhattacharya** and **Neil Ghai**. Edited excerpts:

We often talk about AI as a technological and workplace disruptor. But what does AI disruption

mean for the political economy?

Ultimately technology does not disrupt in its own right. Technology disrupts when it is widely deployed and when it leads to changes in the workplace. We are already seeing changes in the workplace. As a result, we are seeing changes in the labour market and society. Are we looking at another redistribution from labour to capital, or is it going to be more equitable than that? We are already seeing pushbacks against data centres in parts of the world because of their energy and water consumption. To some extent, that reflects some fears about AI. We are seeing governments invest in AI to stay at the cutting edge and avoid falling behind in this geopolitical struggle. You have concerns about data sovereignty and AI sovereignty.



India's youthfulness is an asset. It can absolutely harness and benefit from a demographic dividend. But it requires policies, institutions & infrastructure

The effects are ultimately going to go way beyond just the workplace and workplace productivity, and they're going to be societal and political.

What should business schools be teaching students today that they weren't teaching two years ago, given the rapid rise of AI?

At IMD, we encourage students to use AI for research, presentations and problem-solving. All our students are now also learning to code. AI allows us to rethink how we spend our time. Tasks that once took hours such as quantitative analysis, building datasets, cleaning data or working extensively in Excel, can now be done much faster with AI and other technologies. But that makes it even more important for students to understand

how the technology works, to question its assumptions, and to critically evaluate and verify its output.

India has a huge young workforce, but AI could simultaneously reduce demand for some entry-level white-collar roles. Do you see India's demographic dividend becoming harder to realise unless companies fundamentally rethink how they create entry-level jobs and develop talent?

Demography is a force that works almost like a glacier. It works relatively slowly, but it is an unstoppable force. I wouldn't put too much into the debate over entry-level jobs over the last year or two. India's youthfulness is an asset. It can harness and benefit from a demographic dividend. But it requires policies, institutions, and

infrastructure. It means access to quality education and fostering geographic mobility necessary to match talent with opportunities. And, it requires companies that invest in the next generation and hire.

What will define the next decade more—the return of the state, the rise of geopolitics, or the disruption from AI?

I would pick geopolitics because it is going to shape the behaviour of states.... Ultimately, the AI revolution is going to be channelled through states. What states are going to be able to do with AI is going to depend in no small part on: Do they have access to chips? To data centres? How comfortable they are depending on others? Geopolitics is going to shape the role of states, and it is going to shape AI.

H.E. MOHAMMAD ALI RASHED LOOTAH PRESIDENT & CEO, DUBAI CHAMBERS

Indian AI Talent Could Use Dubai as Global Launchpad

Dubai Chambers working on AI corridor between Dubai & Bengaluru

Team ET

Indian AI talent could use Dubai as a base to enter markets across the Middle East, Africa and CIS countries, Dubai Chambers president and chief executive Mohammad Ali Rashed Lootah said. The business chamber is working to create an AI corridor between Dubai and Bengaluru, he said. "The idea is to create an AI corridor between Dubai and Bengaluru, and then continue to other technology hubs in India," Lootah told ET's Dilasha Seth during a fireside chat.

He said Indian innovation and technology could be implemented in Dubai before being scaled across the wider region.

The proposed corridor comes as Dubai accelerates efforts to make its private sector "powered by agentic AI". The objective is to improve productivity, profitability and service quality across industries, including traditional sectors like manufacturing and retail. "AI is not looked at as a luxury," Lootah said, adding that businesses increasingly wanted to know where and how they could begin adopting the technology.

Dubai Chambers signed two memoranda of understanding during

CREATING OPPORTUNITIES

The challenge is to connect Indian specialists with mkts, investors & entrepreneurial opportunities instead of limiting them to roles within large MNCs



Lootah's recent visit to Bengaluru, one with IT industry body Nasscom and the other with the Federation of Karnataka Chambers of Commerce and Industry.

Access to talent remains critical as governments and companies around the world launch large AI projects, Lootah said.

"The running fuel of any AI project, especially one of a large magnitude, is AI talent, and that talent is available in India," he said.

The challenge, according to him, is to connect Indian specialists with markets, investors and entrepreneurial opportunities instead of limiting them to roles within large multinational companies. Dubai is seeking to position itself as a testing and growth base for such startups, supported by regulatory sandboxes that allow businesses to trial emerging technologies.

Lootah cited Dubai's decision to regulate virtual assets through a dedicated authority as an example of its willingness to frame rules for new sectors.

INDIA'S ADVANTAGE

The running fuel of any AI project, especially one of a large magnitude, is AI talent, and that talent is available in India

Over the past three years, Dubai Chambers has reviewed more than 200 policy proposals with private-sector representatives and submitted recommendations to the government. About 60% of these were accepted, Lootah said.

The technology push comes amid a rapid increase in the number of Indian businesses operating in Dubai. Dubai Chamber of Commerce added 7,579 new Indian companies during the first half of 2026, taking the number of active Indian member companies to 85,841 at the end of June—a 15% increase from a year earlier.

YUVRAJ NARAYAN CEO, DP WORLD

Geopolitical Actors Must Make Peace for Global Growth

Disruption of waterways like Red Sea & Strait of Hormuz driving severe inflationary pressures



Team ET

Logistical workarounds, rerouted corridors, and cargo war insurance cannot fix the mounting crises facing global supply chains without world leaders actively negotiating diplomatic solutions, said DP World CEO Yuvraj Narayan. In a fireside chat at ET World Leaders Forum with Dilasha Seth, he said geopolitical actors should “make peace. It’s not very complicated.” Narayan was commenting on the impact of the Iran crisis that has stunted global supply chains. Highlighting the scale of current disruption, Narayan noted that DP World’s flagship Jebel Ali Port terminal in Dubai is operating at approximately 10% capacity due to ongoing security threats surrounding the strategic Strait of Hormuz. While the company has secured domestic supplies for the UAE, the terminal’s ability to serve the broader global supply chain has been severely impaired. Narayan said DP World executed rapid contingency plans, redeploying 200 engineers, operators, and mobile equipment to activate the UAE’s eastern ports of Fujairah and Khor Fakkan. “Just because I have a life insurance doesn’t mean I’m going to go and hang myself or jump into a

snake pit,” Narayan said. “When safety of navigation around two major waterways in the world gets impaired, insurance doesn’t solve the problem.” The closure and disruption of vital waterways such as the Red Sea and the Strait of Hormuz are driving severe inflationary pressures. “Who do you think pays for it? The ultimate consumer will pay for it,” Narayan said.

CHANGING TACK

Supply chains are diversifying away from hubs like China toward multi-hub models in SE Asia, LatAm and India

These ongoing shocks are accelerating a broader reorganisation of global trade. Supply chains are diversifying away from an over-reliance on single manufacturing hubs like China toward multi-hub models across Southeast Asia, Latin America, and India. Amid this global pivot, Narayan positioned India as a primary beneficiary, praising its vast domestic consumer base, digitised economy, and recent reforms.

MANNY MACEDA CHAIRMAN, BAIN & COMPANY

AI will Have Huge Impact on Consulting Business

There is no longer the ‘truly global CEO’; firms have to choose which nations they want to be in & where to put their assets

Vinod Mahanta

New Delhi: India has an opportunity to benefit from a world being reshaped by artificial intelligence, geopolitical tensions, tariffs, energy security and changing capital flows, but it will need to build the ability to adapt quickly as industries are disrupted, said Manny Maceda, chairman of Bain & Company. “India has been at the centre of disrupting industries for as long as it has been a successful participant on the global stage,” Maceda told ET in an interview. “This is a special time in the world that India can benefit from if it plays it right.” Four dynamics – AI, post-globalisation, energy and the changing cost and availability of capital – are transforming business, with their influence varying across countries and industries, said Maceda who joined Bain back in 1989. The era of firms being able to “make anything anywhere, sell it anywhere and move talent anywhere” is ending, and global organisations need to be more intentional about where they invest, ope-

rate and deploy talent, he said. There is no longer the “truly global CEO” as there used to be. Companies have to choose which nations they want to be in, and where to put their assets, he said. This provides an opportunity for India as China, Europe and regions of the Middle East become increasingly complex markets for global investors, Maceda said.

ORGANISATIONAL CHANGE

Artificial Intelligence is not another tech to deploy, it requires organisational change

India continues to be a compelling destination, especially as corporations are relooking at their supply chains and investment portfolios, he noted. One promising new avenue is the influx of Japanese capital into India’s economy, Maceda said. Indian and Japanese corporations are increasingly exploring an investment

NIGEL VAZ CEO, PUBLICIS SAPIENT

Software Prowess Puts India in a Pole Position for AI

Bigger near-term opportunity is in application layer, where cos can generate returns from existing AI capabilities

Vinod Mahanta

New Delhi: India can leverage its decades-long strength in software and technology services to gain advantage in the artificial intelligence race by focusing on using AI to transform businesses rather than pursuing competition immediately with the US and China in computing power and foundation models, said Nigel Vaz, CEO, Publicis Sapient. The tech leader said India needs to invest in silicon, compute and foundational models, but its bigger near-term opportunity is in the application layer, where companies can generate returns from existing AI capabilities. “The question then becomes: what do you actually do with that capability?” Vaz told ET in an interview. He termed it as a two-speed strategy: developing basic infrastructure, and helping organisations apply AI throughout software development, operations and other functions. Vaz related the development of AI to the arrival of electricity, when increased power generation eventually spurred demand for new applications

and appliances. He claimed that India’s large base of technological workforce and services industry gives it an advantage in terms of applying AI at scale. Publicis Sapient, the digital business transformation unit of Publicis Groupe, is integrating AI into products like Slingshot, which spe-

BUILDING FOUNDATIONS

Govt should focus on building foundations for pvt sector rather than trying to direct industry

eds up software development and modernisation; Bodhi, which manages multiple AI agents across complex workflows; and Sustain, which can identify and resolve technology issues before users experience them. “These are examples of application-level value that India is extraordinarily well positioned to capture,” said Vaz. He emphasised that the Indian government should focus on building the foundations

VIBE CODING, VIBE FILMMAKING, VIBE BUILDING THE FUTURE OF CREATIVITY

India Key AI Market, but Talent Lags

Agriculture, manufacturing, logistics, exports & other traditional sectors could offer major AI opportunities in India

Team ET

India is fast becoming a priority market for artificial intelligence (AI) companies in Silicon Valley, with firms moving from simply selling into the country to building products specifically for Indian users, though the country continues to face gaps in frontier AI talent and risk capital. These opportunities and challenges were discussed during the panel, ‘Vibe Coding, Vibe Filmmaking, Vibe

TANAY KOTHARI

India went from a country that people didn’t prioritise to one of primary mkts people want to come to

Building: The Future of Creativity’, moderated by ET’s Samidha Sharma

The shift in how Silicon Valley sees India has been particularly sharp over the past nine months, said Tanay Kothari, founder of Wispr Flow, an AI dictation app. “India went from a country that people weren’t prioritising building on to being one of the primary markets people wanted to come to,” he said, pointing to companies such as Perplexity, Cursor, and Coinbase. Companies are also beginning to build specifically for India, he said. “You are now starting to see solutions that are built for India,” particularly around multilingual applications and affordability. However, India’s growing importance as an AI market has not translated into a comparable position in frontier AI. Deedy Das, partner at Menlo Ventures, said the country’s weakness at the foundational-model layer comes down largely to risk capital and talent. “When we invested in the Anthropic round, we put in money on a zero-revenue company,” Das said, highlighting the scale of capital required to build frontier models. “You needed to get the compute infrastructure



L-R: Zingroll’s Harshit Yadav, Deedy Das of Menlo Ventures, and Wispr Flow’s Tanay Kothari

to be able to build something like an Anthropic.” The talent equation is equally difficult, he said, as Indian researchers with frontier AI expertise have strong incentives to join established US labs. “If you joined a company like Anthropic or OpenAI three years ago, you’d be worth \$100 billion today,” Das said. “It’s very difficult for somebody to reject that and take a bet on a company which may not have that prospect.”

That leaves India with stronger opportunities in applications and infrastructure, Das said, with the latter seeing investments in “neoclouds.” India’s engineering strength is already an advantage for AI companies building globally, Kothari noted. Wispr Flow, which now has about 90 employees, has teams across engineering, AI, marketing, and sales in India. “The place I found India to have an edge is on the engineering side,” he said. Wispr Flow was valued at \$2 bil-

DEEDY DAS

India’s weakness at the foundational-model layer comes down largely to risk capital and talent

FRONTIER TALENT DIFFICULT TO REPLICATE

The concentration of frontier artificial intelligence talent in San Francisco remains difficult to replicate

lion after raising \$280 million in its latest Series B round, led by Menlo Ventures, taking its total funding to \$361 million. The valuation has nearly tripled from \$700 million nine months earlier. But the concentration of frontier AI talent in San Francisco remains difficult to replicate. “This is just a unique-to-San Francisco thing,” Kothari said, referring to the concentration of people who have worked at OpenAI, xAI, and other leading AI companies. For innovation-heavy roles, he said, “you want that creativity,” making it important for some teams to work together in person. The conversation changes when AI moves into creative applications, where localisation and cultural understanding become central. Harshit Yadav, founder of AI-powered entertainment platform Zingroll, said India became a fast-growing market for the company as users gravitated towards local content. “It’s going to be the localisation of content that needs to be understood well,” Yadav said. Unlike text and coding applications,

creative AI cannot simply be exported across markets because “you really need a taste, kind of a built-in thing”. The San Francisco-based company which also has a team in Delhi, has raised \$2.25 million to date, with backing from Accel and Network VC. It was also selected for the 2026 Accel Atoms and Google AI Futures Fund cohort. Zingroll is continuing to work

HARSHIT YADAV

India became a fast-growing market for the company (Zingroll) as users gravitated towards local content

on its AI-generated Mahabharata project, Yadav said, with the quality of AI video expected to improve as the underlying models mature. “I think you’re going to see a lot more high-quality work going forward,” he said. On the ques-

tion of whether applications can capture the value being created by foundation models, Das said there was no reason they cannot, but warned that companies dependent on external models face the risk of being squeezed as models become cheaper or providers move into their markets. “They can get priced out and lose all distribution,” he said.

The pressure on AI economics is making pricing a central concern for startups. “You’re always thinking about pricing, what is the value that we’re delivering to the customers? How much can we charge for it?” Kothari said. Yadav, meanwhile, said that founders should focus on experimentation and user behaviour rather than competitors. “Just test like there’s no tomorrow. Iterate almost every day and track your data really well,” he said.

For India, the biggest AI opportunity may ultimately lie outside the race to build another frontier model. Kothari pointed to agriculture, manufacturing, logistics, and exports. “It’s a lot of unsexy businesses,” he said, arguing that these sectors are “ready to be disrupted” by AI. Yadav similarly said application-layer opportunities have been largely ignored, and a lot could be done there. There’s a lot of potential in the application layer.

ANTHONY CAPUANO CEO, MARRIOTT INTERNATIONAL

Marriott Believes Deeply in Future of Indian Market

Diverse consumers, price points make India a ‘terrific lab’ for brands and new products



Anumeha Chaturvedi & Vinod Mahanta

New Delhi: India could leapfrog Mexico and China to emerge as Marriott International’s second-largest market globally in the next three to four years, president and CEO Anthony Capuano told ET. The world’s largest hotel chain is expanding aggressively beyond India’s biggest cities, aiming to nearly double its room inventory by tapping a growing domestic appetite for business and leisure travel. The US is Marriott’s largest market currently, followed by China, Mexico, and India. “I would guess that in probably the next three or four years, India will be our second-largest market, and we have no intention of slowing down,” said Capuano. Marriott signed more than 60 deals in India—the highest in its Asia Pacific Excluding China (APEC) region—in the first half of this year. It has more than 200 hotels in its India pipeline, covering more than 30,000 additional rooms, which will almost double its nationwide footprint over the next few years. Marriott currently operates about 230 hotels spanning more than 35,000 rooms in India and expects to enter its 100th city in the country next year, coinciding with its centennial. Capuano said the company believes ‘deeply’ in the future of the Indian market, and those aren’t ‘hollow words.’ “Just in the last year or two, think about how we have demonstrated our belief in India,” he said. “We

chose Ranthambore to announce the launch of our 10,000th hotel globally. We established our tech accelerator in Hyderabad.” “We are pleased with our pace of growth, but we’d like to grow faster,” he said, adding Marriott was also looking for stronger growth in revenue per available room and average room rates. India is also emerging as a testing ground for Marriott International. The company has 19 brands in the country and is pre-

BIG PLANS

In probably 3-4 years, India will be our 2nd-largest market and we have no plan to slow down

paring to launch its 20th, City Express, a transient mid-scale brand acquired through a Latin American deal. The technology accelerator in Hyderabad is aimed at developing and testing initiatives that could eventually be used across its global operations. The diversity of Indian consumers and the range of price points make the country a “terrific laboratory” for testing brands and new products, said Capuano. The chain’s India expansion is now increasingly moving beyond luxury and premium hotels. A significant portion of Marriott’s pipeline is in select-service and mid-scale brands, as the company enters secondary and tertiary markets.

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Volatility transfers wealth from those who can't handle it to those who can

IT Needs Forward Deployed Leadership on the Front Lines to Navigate AI Reset

REWRITING CXO BLUEPRINT The \$315b IT industry needs new skills to ride this code revolution

Beena Parmar

Bengaluru: India's largest export industry—software services—faces its greatest existential threat since inception as artificial intelligence (AI) puts to test the business case for this \$315-billion revenue stream that has transformed cityscapes beyond recognition over the past four decades.

As AI now rewrites the IT business algorithm beyond recognition, Indian technology pureplays have responded with a talent reshuffle that's cascading beyond the corner-room down to the very verticals tasked with bringing home the money.

But are these leadership changes enough? Experts say that the skills required to run these companies are changing and companies should act accordingly. Last month, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) rejigged 14 senior leadership positions and created new business units.

The third and fourth largest IT players—HCLTech and Wipro—promoted existing executives to lead newly carved out industry verticals and units with AI in focus. Experts believe more needs to be done. The capabilities required to lead an IT services com-

AI is challenging the engineered, billing-based model that built India's IT services industry

Traditional metrics such as utilisation, employee pyramids and offshore delivery losing relevance

IT needs leaders with expertise in AI economics, engineering, consulting, domain knowledge and commercialisation

The next leadership generation must transform existing biz while building new AI-led streams

Clients are demanding lower-cost deals as AI-driven productivity reduces the need for software engineers

Revenue is shifting from billing for manpower to pricing based on outcomes, IP and tech

Next Turn

pany are changing, says Jimit Arora, CEO of Everest Group.

"At a CXO-level we don't see elevated leadership churn... This is a time when leaders have to perform and transform simultaneously and lead the AI journey from the front," he said, adding that leadership demand is significantly changing in the race to become AI winners.

In a world obsessed with forward deployed engineers (FDEs), think of the new requirements as Forward Deployed Leadership, Arora added.

"Managing utilisation, pyramids, offshore delivery and large labour-based contracts is no longer enough. Boards now need executives who understand AI economics, platform ecosystems, IP creation, engineering, outcome-based pricing and how to cannibalise existing revenues before someone else does it for them," Phil Fersht, CEO and chief analyst with HFS Group, a US-based IT consultancy and research firm added.

Most experts agree that the next phase requires leaders who can combine those strengths with consulting, domain depth, AI commercialisation, ecosystem management and capital allocation. Fersht notes this is an AI-era leadership reset rather than simply executive churn.



True resilience in the AI era requires replacing yesterday's managers with a new breed of front-line leaders who natively master platform economics and calculated revenue cannibalisation

location. Fersht notes this is an AI-era leadership reset rather than simply executive churn.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Blinkit Shuts its Door on Product Launches Ahead of Festive Rush

Halts new listings to optimise warehouse space & secure truck capacity ahead of sale

Disha Acharya & Pranav Mukul

Bengaluru | New Delhi: Blinkit will freeze new product launches on its platform from August 31 till November 10 to manage high warehouse utilisation ahead of the festive season rush, according to sellers and brands working with India's largest quick commerce platform.

Blinkit will also stop release order (RO) creation for trial, retrieval, and launch for awaited items starting September 10, they said, quoting a note shared with sellers by the company. A release order is sent by platforms to brands to dispatch orders with specific stock-keeping units (SKUs) and locations.

Blinkit's decision to pause new products launched on its platform comes as quick commerce and ecommerce platforms prepare for the festive season sale rush. This year's festive season starts with Onam and Raksha Bandhan this week and will go on till Diwali on November 8.

and appointments have been difficult," said a founder of a D2C personal care brand. This is not limited to Blinkit. Last year, multiple sellers and brands missed listing items on quick commerce for Diwali because platforms paused new listings and pre-launches due to the festive rush.

Industry executives said typically ecommerce and quick-commerce platforms sign advance agreements with middle-mile transporters to lock in fixed truck capacities across key hubs. "Even with 80-90% of the network capacity frozen, companies maintain a 5-10% variable buffer to handle unexpected surges," one of the executives said. A week ahead of Raksha Bandhan, D2C brands across BPC, gifting, fashion, jewellery and more have seen a 20-30% increase in demand for both brother and sister gifting.



This year, quick-comm is expected to account for a higher GMV sale than last year during the festive season: Experts

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Taking Stock

Blinkit to freeze new product launches from Aug 31-Nov 10	REASON High warehouse utilisation
Release orders for trial, retrieval and launch of new items to stop from Sept 10	Platforms lock ops plans 60-90 days ahead to prepare for festive demand

Gifting-focused brands are seeing a 20-30% rise in demand ahead of Raksha Bandhan

Quick-commerce firms are expected to process 14-15m orders on Raksha Bandhan, up from 8-9 million last year



Infosys 1st Qtr Bonus Payout Averages 70% Amid AI Headwinds

Avg payouts drop 10 percentage points from last yr as staff awaits clarity on annual hikes

KR Balasubramanyam

Bengaluru: Infosys paid an average performance bonus of 70% to eligible employees for the April-June period, unchanged from the previous quarter but 10 percentage points lower than a year earlier, people familiar with the matter said.

The latest payout ranged between 65% and 80% across employee levels and performance categories. Employees at job levels (JL) 4 and 5 received slightly higher payouts than those at JL6, with outstanding performers at JL4 and JL5 getting 80% and 78%, respectively.

cluding "outstanding", "commendable" and "met expectations". A separate "non-applicable" category also received payouts. The Bengaluru-headquartered company did not respond to an email seeking details of bonus payment.

Infosys reported a 12% year-on-year increase in consolidated net profit to ₹7,769 crore for the April-June quarter, even as it lowered its annual revenue growth outlook. Meanwhile, employees are awaiting clarity on annual salary hikes.

Numberwise
INFOSYS: WHO GOT WHAT

Figures in %

The latest payout ranged between 65% and 80% across employee levels and performance categories

OS 80%
CD 78%
ME 70%
NA 65%

Tech Buzz

Nvidia in Talks to Invest in AI Co Perplexity



NEW YORK: Nvidia is in talks to invest in Perplexity as part of an equity funding round that would value the AI startup at more than \$30 billion, The Information reported. The funding round would increase Perplexity's valuation by more than 50% from its previous financing a year ago, according to the report. Perplexity's annualised revenue has risen to more than \$750 million from less than \$250 million at the start of the year, the report said. Part of the revenue growth has been driven by Perplexity Computer, a cloud-based AI agent used by professionals to automate computer-based tasks. The Information reported in September last year that Perplexity had finalised a \$20 billion valuation. Earlier this year, Perplexity signed a \$750 million agreement with Microsoft to use its Azure cloud service. —Reuters

50,460
Number of top AI authors and inventors in India in 2025, second only to the US, according to Stanford AI Index Report 2026

\$100,000 H-1B Fee Soon for Foreign Hands



NEW YORK: The Trump administration wants to add an even more expansive \$100,000 fee on the H-1B programme, applying it to individuals hired within the US through regulation after a court blocked a more limited six-figure charge on workers from outside the country. The new \$103,265 fee would be added to all petitions for H-1B workers subject to an annual statutory cap, including those with master's degrees. It "would serve as a dedicated revenue mechanism to help recover a portion of the federal government's costs of administering the lawful immigration system," according to proposed rule released on Monday. The Department of Homeland Security's proposal comes after a court overturned President Donald Trump's \$100,000 charge for H-1B visa holders hired from outside the country. —Bloomberg

Piggybank Deals keep rolling in as investors hunt for winners

Stable Money & Grip Invest Eye Funds as VCs Up Wealthtech Play

Stable Money in talks to raise \$75m more while Grip taps Investec to bag \$20m

Nikhil Patwardhan & Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: Venture capital investors are stepping up bets on wealthtech startups, from micro-savings and fixed-income platforms to firms serving ultra-high-net-worth individuals, as interest grows around financial products for investing and wealth creation.

Stable Money, Grip Invest and Bachatt are in talks for fresh capital, while Nexedge Capital has closed a maiden institutional round.

Stable Money is in talks to raise another \$75 million, comprising about \$50 million in primary capital and \$25 million in secondary transactions. The round is being led by Nandan Nilekani-founded Fundamentum Partnership, with participation from Peak XV Partners, Z47 and others.

The primary infusion is being dis-

On the Money
Stable Money is in talks to raise another \$75 million

\$50m Primary capital

\$25m Secondary transactions

ROUND LED BY
Fundamentum Partnership

PARTICIPATION FROM
Peak XV Partners, Z47 and others

Retail investors are putting around ₹1,500-2,000 crore into corporate bonds every month, compared with ₹300 crore a year earlier, ET reported in June.

German Chip Co Infineon to Buy B'luru's C2i Semi

BENGALURU: German semiconductor major Infineon Technologies on Monday said it will acquire Bengaluru-based power-management semiconductor startup C2i Semiconductors. Financial details of the transaction were not disclosed. The acquisition comes as AI data centres face a growing power crunch, with increasingly powerful GPUs driving up electricity consumption and creating greater demand for efficient power delivery. The acquisition is expected to close in the third quarter 2026. Infineon said it will use C2i's capabilities to create a centre of excellence for digital power tech in India. —Our Bureau

Healthtech Co Healthify Merges with Berry Street in All-stock Deal

The combined entity will be jointly led by its founders as co-CEOs

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Bengaluru-based Healthify has merged with US nutrition care company Berry Street in an all-stock deal, combining the former's AI-led health platform with Berry Street's insurance-backed clinical care network as they look to deepen their presence in the US and expand to international markets.

The combined entity will be led by Healthify founder Tushar Vashisht and Berry Street founder Noah Kotlove as co-CEOs, Vashisht told ET, adding that no immediate capital infusion has been planned. It will continue to operate under the Healthify brand in India and in markets outside the US, while the US business will retain the Berry Street brand.

The merger comes as Healthify's India business has seen revenues decline over the last few years, even as it managed to significantly improve its bottomline. The company offers an AI-powered, subscription-based health and fitness app.

Healthify's India revenue fell to ₹178 crore in FY25 from ₹206 crore in FY24 and ₹229 crore in FY23, according to regulatory filings sourced from business intelligence platform Tofler India. However, its net loss narrowed sharply to ₹4.7 crore in FY25, from ₹88.3 crore in FY24 and ₹142 crore in FY23. To be sure, these figures do not reflect Healthify's overall scale as the company operates across multiple countries. The deal comes roughly 10 months after the two companies first announced a partnership. Soon after entering the US, Vashisht realised that insurance reimbursement would be critical to making the model work in the market, where dietitian consultations are commonly covered by insurance.

Getting Set
Outside the US, Healthify plans to enter mktks including Middle East, western Europe, UK and Australia

In India, the firm plans to lean on pharma, healthcare and corporate partnerships

ures do not reflect Healthify's overall scale as the company operates across multiple countries. The deal comes roughly 10 months after the two companies first announced a partnership. Soon after entering the US, Vashisht realised that insurance reimbursement would be critical to making the model work in the market, where dietitian consultations are commonly covered by insurance.

Next-gen Silicon Wave could See India Leapfrog Global Chip Giants: Experts

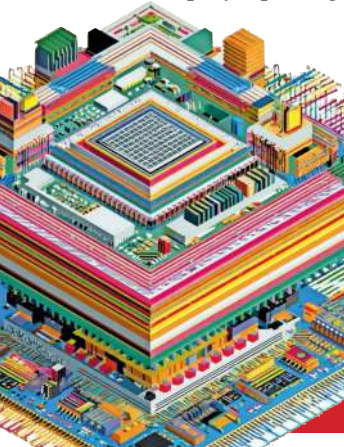
Global chip race is no longer about who started first, but who can learn the fastest, say experts

Suraksha P

Bengaluru: India's late entry into semiconductor manufacturing could prove an advantage as the industry enters a new phase driven by silicon photonics, post-quantum security and neuromorphic computing, giving new entrants a chance to leapfrog established players in these areas, experts told ET.

"India may have entered the semiconductor race late, but the next phase of the industry could offer it an opportunity to catch up, and potentially lead, by learning faster," said Raghav Panicker, chief executive of Kaynes Semicon, which operates an OSAT in Sanand. Silicon photonics uses light

to move data at high speed while consuming less power than conventional electrical interconnects, making it relevant to meet the rapidly expanding



requirements of AI infrastructure and data centres. Post-quantum technologies would be important for protecting communications, critical infrastructure and national security systems against future quantum-enabled attacks, Panicker said.

The third opportunity is in neuromorphic computing, which takes

inspiration from the way the human brain processes information. Unlike conventional systems that continuously process large volumes of data, neuromorphic chips are designed to respond to events, learn and adapt in real time, and process only relevant information. "The race is not about starting first anymore. It's about learning the fastest," Panicker said.

These emerging technologies, where no single country or company has secured decisive dominance, "are becoming important as AI infrastructure faces simultaneous pressures on computing power, bandwidth, energy consumption and security," he noted.

India Semiconductor Mission 1.0 was built around shrinking transistors and improving manufacturing scale.

First in Line
The next phase of semicon industry could offer India an opportunity to catch up

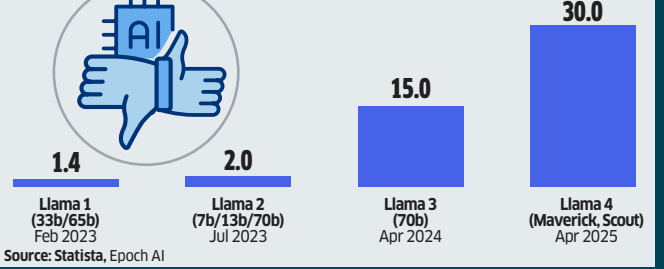
Silicon photonics, co-packaged optics may help meet AI's demands for bandwidth, energy efficiency

Post-quantum security emerging as a critical tech for protecting infra from future quantum attacks

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Meta's Llama AI Developing Raging Hunger for Data Points

Number of unique data points used in training datasets for Meta's Llama AI models (in trillions)



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